2by2 ACADEMY

A STUDENT'S GUIDE, GRADE BY GRADE

THE 4-YEAR ROADMAP



What to do, when to do it, and why it matters to the person reading your application.

the map I wish somebody had handed me. — Jackson

PLEASE DON'T READ THIS COVER TO COVER.

It's 80-something pages. Nobody needs all of them today. Find your row, go where it points, and come back for the rest when you need it.

9th

YOU'RE EARLY. GOOD.

Read the four "Read this first" pages, then Part 1, then **Year 1 → p. 19**.

10th

YOU'RE RIGHT ON TIME.

Same four pages, Part 1, then **Year 2 → p. 28**. Skim Year 1's checklist to catch anything you missed.

11th

THIS IS YOUR YEAR.

Part 1 first (it's short), then **Year 3 → p. 37** and the Toolkit on **p. 57**.

12th

BREATHE. YOU HAVE TIME.

"It is not too late" on **p. 6**, then **Year 4 → p. 49** and the Toolkit. The calendar starts where you are.

Parents

PART 7 IS YOURS.

A few pages, written for you, starting on **p. 82**. Read them before anything else. They take ten minutes.

HOW THE WHOLE THING IS BUILT

PART 1

THE LOGIC

What colleges actually weigh. Read once, use for four years.

PARTS 2-5

YOUR YEAR

Goals, a month-by-month calendar, an on-track check, and the mistakes we see most.

PARTS 6-7 + BONUSES

THE TOOLS

Testing, activities, essays, money. Five worksheets. A section for parents.

Every time you see → **p. 00**, that's a shortcut to the page that goes deeper. Every dashed box with a checkbox is something to actually do.

WHAT'S INSIDE

READ THIS FIRST

Start here: find your row 2
Why you can trust this guide 4
Eight ways to squeeze it dry 5
It is not too late 6
A note from Jackson 7

PART 1 · THE BIG PICTURE

What colleges actually weigh 9
The selectivity shift & our one rule 10
The five pillars 11
Three rules that run through everything 12
The four years at a glance 13
What the best counselors say when nobody is selling 14
Know yourself first & the proof test 17

PART 2 · 9TH GRADE: BUILD THE FOUNDATION

Three goals for the year 20
Month by month 22
Activities, testing, summer, family 24
Am I on track? 26
The mistakes we see most 27

PART 3 · 10TH GRADE: GO DEEPER

Four goals for the year 29
The sophomore drift & your first AP 30
Month by month 31
Activities, testing, summer, family 33
Am I on track? 35
The mistakes we see most 36

PART 4 · 11TH GRADE: THE BIG YEAR

Six goals for the year 38
Why it weighs the most & choosing APs 39
Month by month 41
Will your teachers have something to write? 43
Activities & the testing plan 44
The summer before senior year 45
Drafting the list: a first pass 46
Am I on track? 47
The mistakes we see most 48

PART 5 · 12TH GRADE: EXECUTE

Four goals for the year 50
The application, piece by piece 51
Month by month 52
Decision plans, explained 55
The mistakes we see most 56

PART 6 · THE TOOLKIT

Testing: SAT vs. ACT, dates, prep 58
The activities ladder & the three numbers 60
The four summers 62
Building toward a major 64
Building the college list 65
The personal statement & "Why us?" 67
Recommendations: who and how 69
The activities list: 10 slots, 150 characters 70
Paying for it: FAFSA, CSS, award letters 71

BONUSES & WORKSHEETS

How to bring your parents in 74
The deadline cheat sheet 75
Worksheet 1 · 4-year course plan 76
Worksheet 2 · Activities & impact tracker 77
Worksheet 3 · Summer planner 78
Worksheet 4 · Brag sheet 79
Worksheet 5 · College list builder 80
Glossary 81

PART 7 · FOR PARENTS

What we've learned from the families we've helped 83
The one page for parents 84
If you still want someone in your corner 85

WHY YOU CAN TRUST THIS GUIDE

Fair question. Here's where it came from, how to check it, and what it can't do.

WHERE IT CAME FROM

2by2 is a matchmaker. Our job is finding, vetting and working beside independent college counselors: former admissions officers, people who have read tens of thousands of applications. We've interviewed more than 110 of them and sat in on 350 family calls this cycle alone. We read their plans. We hear what they tell families when nobody is selling anything.

The counselors on our team helped build this guide. One of them holds a Harvard doctorate and fourteen graduate degrees, and his own story has been covered by the national press. What you're holding is their advice, the timelines they refuse to budge on, and the mistakes they've watched families make, written down in plain English.

THE TEAM BEHIND THIS GUIDE, AS FEATURED IN

The New York Times | The Wall Street Journal | TODAY | USA Today | U.S. News & World Report | The Harvard Crimson | The Detroit News

110+
counselors we've interviewed

350
family calls sat in on this cycle

236
families we've helped so far

Don't trust us. Check us.

Test dates come from College Board and ACT. Admissions data comes from NACAC and FairTest. Aid rules come from studentaid.gov and the CSS Profile. The source is named where it's used, so you can look it up yourself.

What this guide can't do

It can't read your transcript, know your school, or see your family's budget. An AI can't either, and your school counselor has hundreds of students. That part takes a person (→ p. 85).

And why me

I'm not the expert here. I'm the one who was in your seat a few years ago, went through four counselors, and then went and asked the experts everything I should have known. This guide is what they told me.

EIGHT WAYS TO SQUEEZE THIS GUIDE DRY

This isn't a book you read once and feel good about. It's a tool. The students who get the most out of it do these eight things.

1 **DECIDE YOU ACTUALLY WANT THIS.**

Not your parents. You. The difference between a student who reads this and one who uses it is a decision made before page one: *I'm going to run my own college process.* If you can say that and mean it, keep going.

2 **READ YOUR YEAR TWICE.**

Once straight through to see the shape. Once slowly, with a pen. Then read the year ahead so you know what you're building toward.

3 **KEEP ASKING: HOW DOES THIS APPLY TO ME?**

A rule that doesn't connect to your school, your classes and your life is just trivia. Make every page personal.

4 **MARK IT UP.**

Underline. Circle the dates. Write "me" next to the mistakes you recognize. A clean copy of this guide is an unused one.

5 **DO THE "AM I ON TRACK?" CHECK EVERY SEMESTER.**

Not once. Every semester. The boxes you can't check are your to-do list for the next six months.

6 **FILL IN THE WORKSHEETS WITH A PARENT.**

The course plan, the activities tracker, the list builder. Filling them in together is where most of the hard conversations happen on their own.

7 **TEACH ONE THING TO A FRIEND.**

If you can explain the activities ladder or the two-columns rule to someone else, you own it. If you can't, read it again.

8 **KEEP A RECORD.**

Start the brag sheet today (→ p. 79). Add to it every semester. In three years, the you writing applications will want to hug the you reading this page.

number 4 is my favorite. wreck this thing.

IT IS NOT TOO LATE. (YES, WE MEAN YOU.)

Whatever grade you're in, whatever your transcript looks like right now, read this before you read anything else.

9th

YOU'RE EARLY. THAT'S THE ENTIRE ADVANTAGE.

Almost nobody in your grade is reading something like this. The habits you build this year compound for three more. You don't need to do anything impressive. You need to do the boring things consistently.

10th

TWO FULL YEARS ARE STILL AHEAD OF YOU ON THE TRANSCRIPT.

At most colleges, 10th and 11th are the two complete years they read most closely. A rough freshman year followed by two strong ones reads as growth. You're standing exactly where the climb starts.

11th

THIS IS THE YEAR THAT DECIDES IT, AND IT'S STILL IN FRONT OF YOU.

Junior year carries more weight than any other. Start now with the right classes, a test date, one activity you own, and two teachers who know you, and you'll apply from a position of strength. Most of your competition hasn't started either.

12th

SENIORS TELL US "IT'S TOO LATE" EVERY SINGLE FALL. IT ISN'T.

Regular Decision deadlines are in January. Your essay can be written in three weeks. Your activities list can be rebuilt in a weekend. A counselor we worked with took on a senior with under 90 days to a deadline, and the family left that call asking how to start. Go to Year 4 (→ p. 49) and the Toolkit. The calendar there starts where you are.

TRUE FOR ALL FOUR

COLLEGES READ TRENDS, NOT SNAPSHOTS.

The question is never "how did you start?" It's **"what did you do once you knew?"** And as of this page, you know.

A NOTE FROM JACKSON

Before you start, you should know who's behind this and why it exists.

Halfway through 5th grade, I landed in America. New language. New school. A system nobody explained.

I figured most of it out the hard way. College was different, though. You don't get to figure that one out twice.

So in high school I went through counselors. One. Two. Three. Smart people, good résumés. None of them really got me. Then I met number four. Same kid, same story. The only difference was that someone finally knew how to tell it. I got into a top-20 university, and not because I turned into a different student. The right person saw what was already there.

Here's the part nobody tells you: **the best counselor on paper isn't always the best counselor for you.** And the map I needed in 9th grade didn't exist. Nobody showed me the timeline until I was already behind it.

Three things I'd tell my 9th-grade self

- **Nobody is coming to explain the system to you.** That's not bad news. It means the student who reads the map beats the student who waits for one.
- **Fit matters more than credentials.** In counselors, in colleges, in everything. The right fit gets more out of you than the "best" option ever will.
- **Your story is already there.** You don't have to manufacture one. You have to notice it, build on it, and learn to tell it. That's what the rest of these pages are for.

You'll see yellow **"Jackson's note"** boxes through the guide. Those are the spots where my own experience has something to add. Everything else comes from people who've done this far longer than I have.

— Jackson

01

PART 1

THE BIG PICTURE

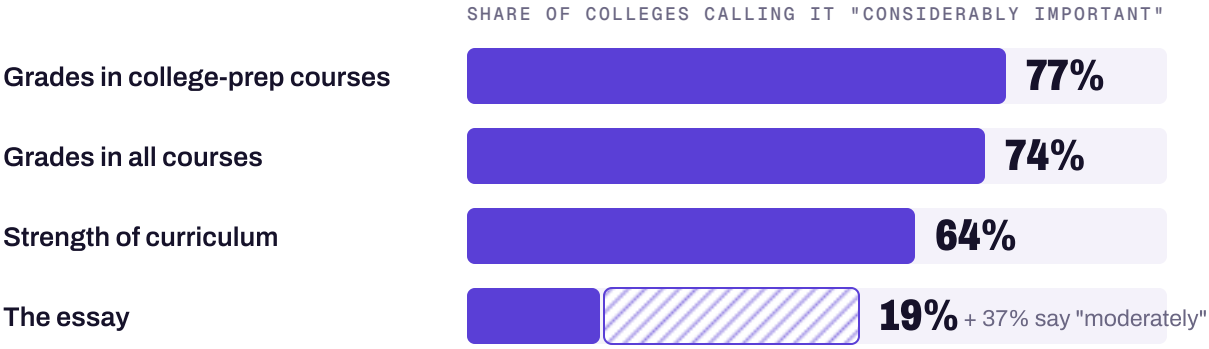
Before the calendar, the logic. Once you know what an admissions reader is actually looking for, every item on the timeline stops being a chore and starts being a choice.

What colleges actually weigh	9	The selectivity shift	10
The five pillars	11	Three rules for everything	12
Four years at a glance	13	What the best counselors say	14
Know yourself first	17	The proof test	18

15 minutes here saves you about four years of guessing.

WHAT COLLEGES ACTUALLY WEIGH

Every year, the National Association for College Admission Counseling asks colleges which parts of an application carry "considerable importance." The answer has barely moved in two decades: your transcript, by a mile.



Source: NACAC, *State of College Admission* factors survey (2023 data). Share of four-year colleges rating each factor of "considerable importance."

WHAT THAT MEANS FOR YOU

1. **RIGOR PLUS GRADES IS THE WHOLE GAME AT MOST SCHOOLS.**
   Not rigor alone. Not grades alone. The combination.

2. **YOUR TRANSCRIPT IS FOUR YEARS LONG.**
   There is no "doesn't count" year. An upward trend from a rocky start gets read generously. A downward one doesn't.

3. **EVERYTHING ELSE IS A TIEBREAKER. UNTIL IT ISN'T.**
   At most colleges, testing, activities and essays decide between similar applicants. At the most selective schools, where nearly everyone has the grades, they *are* the decision.

So if you remember one sentence from this page: take the hardest classes you can do well in, and do well in them. The rest of this guide is about everything that goes on top.

THE SELECTIVITY SHIFT

The more selective the college, the more the "other stuff" matters. Why? Because most of the applicant pool has already cleared the academic bar.

IF THE COLLEGE ADMITS…	WHAT DECIDES IT
50%+ of applicants	Grades and rigor, often with a GPA/test formula. Activities and essays rarely change outcomes.
20–50%	Grades and rigor first. Testing (where required or submitted), then activities and essays break ties.
Under 20%	Grades and rigor are the entry ticket. Impact, voice, recommendations and fit make the decision.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR PLANNING

You don't know yet which bucket your eventual list will land in. So this roadmap builds the transcript first, because it's the only thing every college weighs heavily, and layers everything else on top in a way that doesn't cost you grades.

OUR ONE RULE

COLLEGES READ YOU IN CONTEXT.

The question is never "did you do everything?" It's **"did you make the most of what was in front of you?"**

Every high school sends colleges a **school profile**, and your transcript is read right next to it. You are not competing with a student whose school offers 25 APs when yours offers 6. You're being asked whether you took the most demanding path *your* school made available, and did well on it.

Jackson's note

This rule is the reason I stopped comparing myself to kids at schools I never went to. You get judged on what you did with your shot. Not theirs.

THE FIVE PILLARS

Every task on the four-year calendar builds one of these five things. Not sure something is worth your time? Ask which pillar it serves. If the answer is "none," skip it.

PILLAR 1

RIGOR

How strong your course load is *relative to what your school offers*. Honors, AP, IB, dual enrollment, and sticking with subjects when everyone else drops them.

PILLAR 2

GRADES

How you did in those courses, read as a four-year trend. Core subjects count most.

PILLAR 3

TESTING

SAT or ACT, plus AP/IB scores. Most colleges are test-optional, but the most selective have largely gone back to requiring scores. Plan to have one.

PILLAR 4

IMPACT

What you did outside class, and what changed because you did it. Depth beats breadth. Ownership beats titles.

PILLAR 5

VOICE

The person behind the numbers: your essays, your teachers' recommendations, your interview, and the character that shows through all of them. This is the pillar most students start too late (September of senior year) and the one that decides outcomes when everyone has the grades.

How it gets built: a running brag sheet from 9th grade on · real relationships with two or three teachers, especially in 11th · a first personal-statement draft the summer before senior year.

PILLAR	9TH	10TH	11TH	12TH
Where the work peaks	Grades, habits	Rigor, Impact	All five at once	Voice

THREE RULES THAT RUN THROUGH EVERYTHING

You'll see these again and again in the year-by-year pages. Learn them once here.

1

THE COMPOUNDING RULE

Each year's options are set by the year before. The AP you can take in 11th depends on the honors class you took in 10th, which depended on the track you picked in 9th. **Course selection every February is the most important 30 minutes of your school year.** Most people spend it filling out a form in homeroom.

2

THE TWO-COLUMNS RULE

Keep two lists: things you do because they interest you, and things you do because you think you should. Over four years, the first list should grow and the second should shrink. **Colleges can tell the difference.** So can everyone else.

3

THE DOCUMENTATION RULE

Start one document today: your brag sheet. Every semester, add what you did, your roles, hours, awards, and one sentence about what you learned. Your senior-year self and your recommenders will thank you. Template on **p. 79**.

☐ DO THIS TODAY

Open a blank doc. Title it "Brag sheet." Write down what you did last summer. That's it. You've now started something most seniors wish they had three years of.

Jackson's note

The two-columns rule is the one I'd tattoo on a freshman if that were allowed. Every hour you spend on a "should" is an hour you didn't spend getting good at the thing that would've made your application yours.

THE FOUR YEARS AT A GLANCE

One theme per year. Get the theme right and most of the details take care of themselves.

	9TH · BUILD	10TH · DEEPEN	11TH · PERFORM	12TH · EXECUTE
Goal	Strong habits, a schedule that stretches you a little, honest exploration	Upward grade trend with more rigor; 2–3 activities with responsibility	Strongest transcript year, testing done, real leadership, a drafted list	Apply early and well, keep the grades, finish the story
Classes	Five cores. Honors where you're strong. Start a language.	First AP(s) in your strongest subjects	Most rigorous year. APs aligned to a likely major.	Don't drop rigor. Colleges see it.
Activities	Try 4–6. Finish the year in 2–3.	Pick your lane. Member → contributor.	Lead something. Scale a project. Measure results.	Sustain. Document outcomes.
Testing	PSAT 8/9 if offered. Read.	Practice PSAT. Diagnostic SAT & ACT; choose one.	PSAT/NMSQT (counts). First test in spring; retake by June.	Final retake Aug–Oct if needed
Summer	**Explore.** A job, a camp, a skill, reading.	**Launch.** One substantial thing for 6–8 weeks.	**Prove.** The experience you'd write about. Essay draft #1.	**Celebrate.** Then orientation.
Family	First money conversation	Casual visits to 3 different campuses	Net price calculators. Set a budget. Talk about ED.	FAFSA & CSS in October. Compare offers in April.

Build
→ Deepen → Perform → Execute. Four words. That's the whole roadmap.

February
is the month that matters every year. Course selection. Put it in your phone.

Summer
is a third of high school and the only part you fully control.

screenshot this page. seriously.

WHAT THE BEST COUNSELORS SAY WHEN NOBODY IS SELLING

We've sat in on a lot of first conversations between veteran counselors and families. The same ideas keep coming up, usually as a picture instead of a rule. These are the ones worth carrying around for four years.

"You're not competing with every applicant."

You're competing with students who look like you on paper: same region, same kind of school, same intended major. That's who your application sits next to in the pile. So the question isn't "am I good enough?" It's **"what do I have that the student next to me doesn't?"**

"Grades get you read. They don't get you in."

At selective colleges, most applicants are qualified. Strong grades and rigor buy you a careful read. They aren't the reason for a yes. Everything else in this guide (activities, summers, essays, recommendations) is what that careful reader is looking for.

"Thousands of students have your grades. What makes you not a commodity?"

A counselor asked a student with near-perfect grades this question. The student had no answer. That silence is the problem most strong students have and don't know they have. Depth in something, a project you started, a point of view: those make a file memorable. Start building the answer now.

"Seventeen years of your life in 650 words."

That's the personal statement. It's why counselors say to keep it small and specific (one moment, told closely) and skip the grand tour of everything you've done. It's also why it can't be written in a weekend in October.

"You don't need to be Superman. You need to be Batman."

Superman is perfect, and Hollywood still makes more movies about Batman. Colleges feel the same way. A student who is interesting, who has a thing, a story, even a hardship they've built on, beats one who is flawless and flat. If you're a perfectionist, this is permission. If you've had a hard road, this is why it can be an asset.

WHAT THE BEST COUNSELORS SAY, CONTINUED

"A family doctor, a neurologist, a neuro-oncologist."

The more you specialize, the more valuable you become. "Well-rounded" is what every applicant is. Show a reader twenty well-rounded students and ask them to pick the best one. They can't. Show them one student who went deep on something and they remember the name. **By 11th grade, be the neuro-oncologist of something.**

"Everyone knows who founded Amazon. Few know who runs it now."

Colleges remember founders. Starting something (a club, a program, a publication, a small business) says more than joining ten things. It doesn't need to be big. It needs to be yours, and it needs to exist.

"Jefferson wrote 23 drafts of the Declaration of Independence."

Your essay is going to take more than three. Counselors say this to set expectations: the first draft is supposed to be bad. The work is in the revisions, and the students who resent the fifth draft usually haven't written anything good yet.

"Painters say clouds are the hardest part."

Sometimes one cloud takes a week. Experience is what tells you when it's done. That's the real case for having someone who's seen a thousand applications look at yours. Not a checklist. Judgment about when something is finished and when it only *looks* finished.

"I'm Yoda. You're Luke."

The good ones don't write your essay. They don't manufacture your activities. You do the work and you keep your voice. They guide. If anyone offers to do it for you (a counselor, a parent, an AI), the result will read like it, and readers can tell.

Jackson's note

The Batman one is my favorite, because for years I thought the stuff that made me different was the stuff I needed to hide. It turned out to be the application.

WHAT THE BEST COUNSELORS SAY, CONTINUED

"Even great teachers take shortcuts with recommendation letters."

People circle the gym parking lot hunting for a closer spot, then walk inside and get on the StairMaster. Teachers with forty letters to write do the same thing: they write from whatever is in front of them. Give a teacher specific material (a brag sheet, two moments from class, what you learned) and you get a specific letter. Give them nothing and you get a template.

"Give your mom a hug tonight."

That's the last thing one counselor said to a student at the end of a 90-minute conversation about her future. The student's reply: it had been just her and her mom for a long time.

The college process is a family's process. The parents reading this guide next to you are not the enemy of your independence. They're the people who will drive you to the campus visits. **Bring them in.** Part 7 (→ p. 82) is written for them, and p. 74 gives you the exact text to send.

☐ DO THIS TONIGHT · THE BEST SINGLE EXERCISE IN THIS GUIDE

"Before you sleep, write down three things no one else at your school could say about themselves."

A counselor gave this as homework at the end of a first call. Three lines. If you can fill them, you just found the start of your essay. If you can't, you just found your project for the next year. Either way you win.

How to use these. Each line is a picture of a rule somewhere in this guide. When a page starts to feel abstract, flip back here and find the picture that goes with it. Families forget arguments. They remember stories.

KNOW YOURSELF FIRST

Every year in this guide tells you to "pick your lane." Almost nobody tells you how. This page is how. Three questions, ten minutes, a pen.

1

ASK "WHY" UNTIL IT GETS SPECIFIC.

Write down the subject or activity you like most. Then ask why, and ask why again about your answer. "I like biology" → "I like figuring out how systems break" → "I like fixing things people gave up on." The third answer is the useful one.

2

WHAT DO YOU DO WHEN NOBODY'S MAKING YOU?

Not assigned, not graded, nobody watching. What you read, build, watch, fix, argue about or keep coming back to. Be truthful, even if it sounds unimpressive.

3

WHEN WERE YOU AT YOUR BEST?

One specific day or project. What were you doing, who was it for, and what made it hard?

NOW LOOK FOR THE OVERLAP

WHERE TWO OF YOUR THREE ANSWERS POINT THE SAME WAY, THAT'S A LANE WORTH TESTING.

Testing, not marrying. Try it for a semester: one class, one activity, one small project. Redo this page every summer. Most students' answers change between 9th and 11th grade, and that's the point of doing it early.

THE PROOF TEST

Anyone can write "I'm curious" or "I'm a leader." Readers believe what you can back up. So before you claim something about yourself, run it through this.

THE TEST

CAN I NAME THREE SPECIFIC MOMENTS FROM THE LAST TWELVE MONTHS THAT SHOW IT?

Three: it's real, and you have material. One or two: it's starting, so keep going. Zero: it's something you want to be true. That's fine. Now you know what to go do.

TRY IT ON THREE THINGS YOU'D SAY ABOUT YOURSELF

WHAT I'D CLAIM	MOMENT 1	MOMENT 2	MOMENT 3

WHERE YOU'LL USE THIS

ESSAYS

Every quality you want a reader to see needs a moment behind it (→ p. 67).

ACTIVITIES LIST

The moments become your numbers and verbs (→ p. 61).

RECOMMENDATIONS

Hand teachers the moments from their class and they write a specific letter (→ p. 69).

BRAG SHEET

Log moments as they happen, and this test takes two minutes in senior year (→ p. 79).

no proof yet isn't a problem. it's a to-do list.

9

PART 2 · YEAR 1

9TH GRADE: BUILD THE FOUNDATION

Freshman year is not a warm-up. It's the year your habits get set, your course track gets chosen, and your transcript starts. The goal isn't to be impressive yet. It's to build the machine that makes you impressive later.

Three goals for the year	20	Why this year matters	21
Month by month	22	Activities & testing	24
Summer #1 & the family talk	25	Am I on track?	26

your only job this year: be boring, consistently.

9th BUILD · **10th** DEEPEN · **11th** PERFORM · **12th** EXECUTE

THREE GOALS FOR THE YEAR

If you do nothing else this year, do these three. That's a real offer. Three things, done properly, and freshman year is a win.

1

EARN THE BEST GRADES YOU CAN IN A SCHEDULE THAT STRETCHES YOU A LITTLE.

Not the hardest schedule possible. One honors class in your strongest subject is plenty. Protect the GPA, because it's cumulative from day one.

2

TRY 4–6 THINGS. FINISH THE YEAR IN 2–3.

Clubs, a sport, an instrument, a job, volunteering, a hobby you take seriously. Whatever you keep, commit to it through the year. Quitting in October tells you nothing.

3

BUILD THE SYSTEMS.

A planner you actually open. A consistent sleep schedule. A place and a time to study. And the habit of going to teachers' office hours *before* you're in trouble.

THE HONEST TEST FOR HONORS

"CAN I EARN AN A OR A HIGH B HERE WITH A REASONABLE AMOUNT OF WORK?"

If yes, take it. If the truthful answer is "only if I give up sleep and everything else," take the standard class and get the A. You can step up next year from a stronger base.

NOW YOURS

My three goals this year, in my own words:

Jackson's note

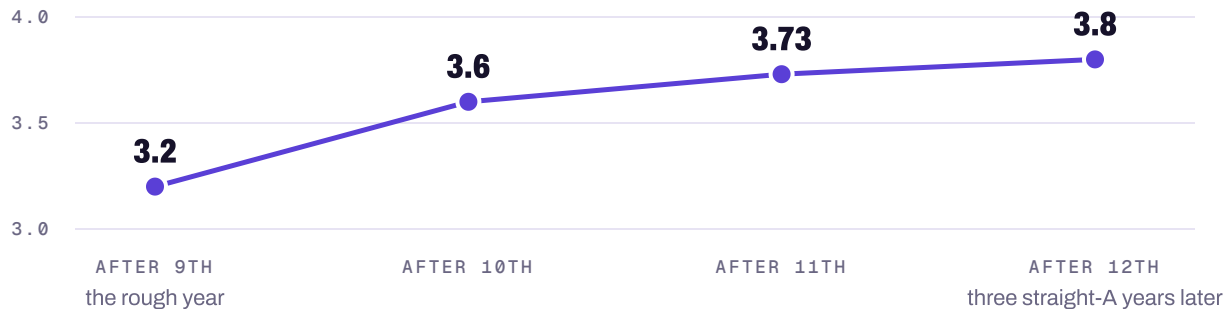
Nobody posts about goal #3. Nobody gets a trophy for owning a planner. It's still the one that quietly decides the other two.

"FRESHMAN YEAR DOESN'T REALLY COUNT."

You'll hear that from students. You'll hear it from plenty of parents too. Two things make it wrong.

- **It's on the transcript.** With a few exceptions (the University of California system calculates GPA from 10th and 11th grade only), colleges see all four years and count 9th in your cumulative GPA.
- **It sets the track.** Whether you can take AP Calculus senior year is decided by which math class you're sitting in right now. Whether you'll have four years of a language depends on whether you start one this fall.

WHAT A ROUGH 9TH GRADE DOES TO YOUR CUMULATIVE GPA



The good news: a 3.2 freshman year still averages out to a 3.8 if the next three are straight A's. Colleges read trends. A student who stumbles in 9th and climbs steadily gets read generously. What's hard to recover from is a strong start that fades.

WHAT "A SCHEDULE THAT STRETCHES YOU" LOOKS LIKE

SUBJECT	THE TYPICAL 9TH-GRADE MOVE
English	Honors if you're a strong reader and writer. Otherwise standard, and read on your own.
Math	Stay on (or get on) the track that reaches Precalculus by 11th. Geometry or Algebra II as a freshman keeps Calculus available senior year.
Science	Biology or Physical Science, whichever your school sequences first. Honors if it's offered and you're strong.
History	World History or Geography. Standard is fine here for most students.
Language	Start (or continue) one and plan to stay four years. Selective colleges strongly prefer level 4.
Elective	Something you're curious about. This is where exploring is free.

Fill in your own version on Worksheet 1, the 4-year course plan (→ p. 76).

MONTH BY MONTH: AUGUST TO JANUARY

AUG–SEP

SET UP

- **Set up your systems:** one planner, a Sunday weekly review, a fixed study block on school nights.
- **Introduce yourself to your school counselor.** Ask two questions: "What does our school profile say?" and "What's the path to the most rigorous schedule here?"
- Go to the club fair and sign up for more than you'll keep. Try a fall sport or a performing-arts group if either interests you.
- Start your brag sheet (→ p. 79). First entry: what you did last summer.

OCT

FIRST CHECK

- First progress reports. If any grade is below where you want it, **see the teacher this month**, not at finals.
- Take the PSAT 8/9 if your school offers it (Oct 1–30 window). Zero prep. It's a baseline.
- Decide which fall activities you're keeping. Drop the rest without guilt.

NOV–DEC

FINISH STRONG

- Build a finals plan two weeks out: one subject per day, past tests and problem sets first.
- Ask one teacher how you could have done better this semester. The answer is usually specific and usable.
- Winter break: rest, then read. Two books you picked yourself.

JAN

RESET

- Review first-semester grades without flinching. What worked? What didn't? **Adjust the system, not just the effort.**
- Update the brag sheet with fall activities, roles and hours.

☐ THIS WEEK

Email or stop by your school counselor and ask those two questions. Most freshmen never do. You'll be remembered for it, and that matters when this person writes about you in three years.

MONTH BY MONTH: FEBRUARY TO SUMMER

FEB–MAR

THE BIG DECISION

- **Course selection for 10th grade. The most important 30 minutes of the year.** Bring the 4-year course plan (→ p. 76) to your counselor meeting. Confirm: math track, language continuation, and one or two honors classes where you're strongest.
- If your school offers AP courses to sophomores (commonly AP World History, AP Human Geography, AP Computer Science Principles), decide now whether one fits.
- Look at summer options: local jobs, camps, volunteer programs, a skill you want to learn. Many free or low-cost programs have spring deadlines.

APR–MAY

CLOSE OUT

- Same finals plan as December. It's a system now.
- Pick your 2–3 keepers for next year and think of one way to contribute more in each (run an event, help with the website, mentor a new member).
- End-of-year reflection in the brag sheet: biggest win, biggest struggle, what you want more of.

SUMMER

EXPLORE

- Summer #1 is for exploring, not résumé-building. A part-time job, a camp, a volunteer role, a skill project, and reading.
- Pick one thing to go deep on for 3–4 weeks. The point is to learn what sustained effort on something *you chose* feels like.
- Two weeks before school: look at your 10th-grade schedule and preview the hardest class.

THE ONE DATE THAT MATTERS MOST THIS YEAR

COURSE SELECTION, IN FEBRUARY OR MARCH.

Everything you'll want available in 11th grade (the APs, the math level, the fourth year of language) gets opened or closed by what you choose now. **Don't let it be a form you fill out in homeroom.**

ACTIVITIES: BREADTH IS THE POINT

Nobody can pick a lane before they've seen the options. Use this year to sample widely, then watch for the thing you'd do even if nobody was keeping score.

- **Commit for the year** to whatever you keep past October. Readers notice four-year involvement. They also notice a list of one-semester stints.
- **Track hours and roles as you go.** The Common App asks for hours per week and weeks per year for every activity. Nobody remembers that three years later.
- **Don't ignore "unofficial" activities.** Caring for siblings, a family business, a job, a serious hobby, a faith community. All of it counts, and it often says more about you than a club.
- **Look for one activity with a ladder:** a visible path from newcomer to leader (a team, a publication, robotics, student government, a youth organization). More on the ladder on p. 60.

Jackson's note

If you're new to this country, or your parents didn't go to college here, the activities list can feel like a language you don't speak. It did for me. The thing nobody told me: **what you already do counts.** Translating for your parents. Working in the family business. Helping your siblings. Those are activities. Write them down. Then add one thing that's just for you.

TESTING: NOT YET

There is nothing to prep for in 9th grade. The PSAT 8/9, if your school offers it, is a free baseline. Take it cold and file the score.

What actually moves future test scores is reading. Vocabulary, speed and comprehension get built over years, not in a six-week prep course. Fifteen minutes a day of anything you enjoy reading is the best SAT prep a freshman can do. (Yes, anything. The back of the cereal box is pushing it.)

SUMMER #1: EXPLORE

The first summer should answer one question: what am I actually curious about?

Free or low-cost (start here)

- A job: lifeguard, retail, tutoring, camp counselor-in-training
- Volunteering with a cause you care about
- Library or community-college summer classes
- A self-taught skill: coding, design, a language, an instrument
- A reading list you build yourself

Worth paying for (sometimes)

- Academic camps in a subject you love
- Sports or arts intensives if you're serious
- Travel with a purpose: language immersion, service

Skip: expensive "pre-college" programs sold as admissions boosts. They aren't.

THE CONVERSATION TO HAVE WITH YOUR FAMILY

MONEY, EARLY

"ROUGHLY WHAT CAN WE AFFORD PER YEAR FOR COLLEGE, AND WILL WE NEED FINANCIAL AID?"

The answer shapes your college list three years from now. Families who have this conversation in 9th grade avoid the heartbreak of a senior falling in love with a school that was never affordable.

Also worth settling: who owns this process. The student does. Parents support, remind and fund. They don't fill out forms or write emails to teachers.

Jackson's note

That money question feels awkward to ask. Ask it anyway. It's a lot less awkward in 9th grade than it is in April of senior year with an acceptance letter in your hand.

AM I ON TRACK?

Check each box at the end of the year. No one's grading this but you, so don't round up.

- [ ] I finished the year with grades I'm proud of in every core class. No grade I'd want to explain away.
- [ ] I'm on a math track that reaches at least Precalculus by 11th grade.
- [ ] I'm taking a world language and plan to continue through level 4.
- [ ] My 10th-grade schedule includes at least one honors (or AP) class in a subject I'm strong in.
- [ ] I have a planner or system I actually use, and a consistent sleep schedule on school nights.
- [ ] I tried at least four activities this year and am continuing two or three.
- [ ] At least one of my activities has a visible path to more responsibility.
- [ ] I have a brag sheet with my activities, hours and roles filled in.
- [ ] I know at least one teacher well enough that they'd recognize me outside class.
- [ ] My family and I have had a first real conversation about what college can cost us.

8–10
On track. Keep going.

5–7
Pick two to fix this summer.

0–4
Not behind. But 10th grade needs a plan. Bring this page to a counselor.

the unchecked boxes aren't a grade. they're your to-do list.

THE MISTAKES WE SEE MOST

Four ways freshmen make the next three years harder than they need to be, and what to do instead.

OVERLOADING ON HONORS TO "LOOK GOOD"

Three honors classes and a 3.1 is worse than one honors class and a 3.9. Rigor gets weighed *with* grades, not instead of them.

DO INSTEAD → **Step up gradually. One honors class in your best subject, then add.**

TREATING 9TH AS A FREE YEAR

It's a third of the GPA colleges see before you apply (9th, 10th and 11th are all that's on the transcript at submission). And the habits you form now are the ones you'll have in 11th.

DO INSTEAD → **Build the systems from goal #3 before you need them.**

QUITTING THE LONG-TERM THINGS

The instrument you've played since 4th grade. The language you started in middle school. The sport you're decent at. Years of continuity are rare and valuable.

DO INSTEAD → **Don't trade them for a club you'll forget by spring.**

PARENTS RUNNING THE SHOW

When a parent emails the teacher, picks the activities and manages the planner, the student shows up in 11th grade without the skills the next three years demand.

DO INSTEAD → **Parents: support from the side, not the front. Students: send your own emails.**

That's 9th grade. Grades, a few activities you like, systems that run without drama. If you've got those, you are miles ahead of where most people think they need to be. Next up: the year where good students drift.

10

PART 3 · YEAR 2

10TH GRADE: GO DEEPER

Sophomore year is where good students drift. The novelty is gone, junior year feels far away, and nothing seems urgent. That's exactly why it's the year that separates students who arrive at 11th grade ready from those who arrive scrambling.

Four goals for the year	29	The drift & your first AP	30
Month by month	31	Activities & testing	33
Summer #2 & the family talk	34	Am I on track?	35

nobody's watching this year. that's the opportunity.

9th BUILD · **10th DEEPEN** · 11th PERFORM · 12th EXECUTE

FOUR GOALS FOR THE YEAR

Treat 10th grade as the dress rehearsal for 11th. Same stage, lower stakes, and you get to find out what breaks.

1 **AN UPWARD (OR STEADY) GRADE TREND, WITH MORE RIGOR.**

Add one step of difficulty (a first AP or a second honors class) and hold or raise your grades. That combination is what readers love to see.

2 **PICK YOUR LANE: 2–3 ACTIVITIES, AND TAKE ON RESPONSIBILITY.**

Move from "member" to "the person who runs X." Start thinking about a project of your own.

3 **GET A TESTING BASELINE AND CHOOSE SAT OR ACT.**

One full, timed practice test of each this winter. Pick the one that fits. No heavy prep yet.

4 **A FIRST SUBSTANTIVE SUMMER.**

A program, a job, research, or a self-directed project you'd be glad to describe to an adult.

ONE NUMBER TO KNOW

SOPHOMORE YEAR IS HALF OF THE "REAL" TRANSCRIPT.

At most colleges, 10th and 11th are the two full years on your transcript when you apply. (Senior first-semester grades arrive later, in the mid-year report.) So the year that feels like it doesn't matter is one of the two that matter most.

☐ NOW YOURS

My three goals this year, in my own words:

THE SOPHOMORE DRIFT, AND HOW TO DODGE IT

Here's what happens to a lot of capable students in 10th grade.

Grades slide half a letter. Activities stay at "I go to meetings." The summer gets filled by default. None of it feels like a problem. **Then spring of junior year shows up**, the transcript has a dip right where colleges look hardest, and the activities list shows no growth.

The fix is boring, and it works:

TAKE THE FIRST AP NOW

So the first time you sit an AP exam isn't the year everything counts.

TAKE A LEADERSHIP STEP NOW

So you're not asking for a title in 11th with nothing behind it.

DO A SERIOUS SUMMER NOW

So next summer builds on something you already started.

THE FIRST AP: HOW TO CHOOSE IT

1. ### AM I STRONG IN THIS SUBJECT?

   Your first AP should be in a strength. The goal is an A and a 4 or 5 on the exam, not survival.

2. ### DOES IT BUILD TOWARD SOMETHING?

   AP World → AP US History → AP Government is a sequence. So is AP CS Principles → AP CS A. Random APs are fine. Connected ones tell a story.

3. ### WHAT'S THE TEACHER'S TRACK RECORD?

   Ask older students. A well-taught AP in a "softer" subject beats a badly taught one in a "hard" subject.

Common sophomore APs: World History, Human Geography, European History, Computer Science Principles, Psychology, Environmental Science, Seminar. Some schools also allow AP Biology or Chemistry for strong science students on an accelerated track.

Jackson's note

Drift doesn't feel like drifting. It feels like "I'm fine." That's what makes it dangerous. Do the on-track check on p. 35 in December, not just June.

MONTH BY MONTH: AUGUST TO DECEMBER

AUG–SEP

RECOMMIT

- **Schedule check in week one.** Fix errors immediately. Honors and AP waitlists close fast.
- In each of your 2–3 activities, ask the advisor: **"What needs doing that nobody's doing?"** Then do it.
- Set a semester GPA target and work backward to the grade you need in each class.

OCT

PRACTICE PSAT

- Take the PSAT/NMSQT (Oct 1–30 window) as practice if it's offered to sophomores. It doesn't count for National Merit until 11th. It's a free look at the real format.
- Progress reports: below target → see the teacher this month.
- Notice which teachers you connect with. Junior-year teachers usually write recommendations, but a 10th-grade teacher who advises your activity can be a strong second letter.

NOV–DEC

FINALS + LOOK AHEAD

- Finals plan, two weeks out.
- **Over break, research summer programs.** Selective ones often have January–March deadlines and need a teacher recommendation. Ask before break ends.
- PSAT scores arrive in December. Read the section breakdown, not just the total.

THE QUESTION THAT CHANGES YOUR ACTIVITIES LIST

"WHAT NEEDS DOING THAT NOBODY'S DOING?"

Ask it once per activity in September. Whatever the answer is, that's your job now. This is how "member" turns into "the person who runs X" without anyone having to vote for you.

☐ OVER WINTER BREAK

Make a list of five summer programs, jobs or projects and write the deadline next to each. Deadlines are in winter. Decide in January, not June.

MONTH BY MONTH: JANUARY TO SUMMER

JAN–FEB

DIAGNOSTIC

- **Take one full-length, timed practice SAT and one practice ACT** (free official tests exist for both). Compare percentiles, pick the better fit (→ p. 58), and don't look back.
- **Course selection for 11th grade**, the hardest year on the transcript. APs where you're strong and that point toward a likely major. All five cores. Don't drop the language.
- Submit summer program applications.

MAR–APR

BUILD

- Take the PSAT 10 if offered (Mar 1–Apr 30 window).
- **Take a leadership step:** propose an event, fundraiser or initiative inside one activity. Write down the goal and how you'll know it worked.
- Plan a self-directed summer project: something you create, not something you join.

MAY–JUN

FINISH + AP

- AP exams run May 3–14, 2027. Start four weeks out. Past free-response questions are the best material.
- Finals, then update the brag sheet with every role, hour count and result from the year. Thank the teachers you connected with.

SUMMER

LAUNCH

- **One thing of substance at the center:** a program, a job with real responsibility, research, or the project you planned in April. Six to eight weeks of focus.
- Light test prep only if the diagnostic showed a clear gap: 10–20 hours of timed sections. Heavy prep comes in 11th.
- Casually visit two or three very different campuses. You're learning preferences, not picking schools.

"pick the better fit and don't look back" = stop re-deciding. just prep.

ACTIVITIES: FROM MEMBER TO CONTRIBUTOR

By the end of 10th grade, each of your main activities needs an answer to one question: "What did you specifically do there?" Not "attended meetings." Something with your fingerprints on it.

- **Volunteer for the unglamorous job.** Treasurer, logistics, the newsletter. That's how you learn how the thing actually works, and it's how real leadership starts.
- **Start measuring.** Members recruited, dollars raised, events run, people served. Numbers make an activities list believable (→ p. 61).
- **Plant one seed of your own.** A project that exists because you decided it should. Small is fine. Yours is the point.
- **Let something go** if it lives in the "because I should" column.

TESTING: THE BASELINE YEAR

The only testing goal this year is information: a practice PSAT in the fall, and one timed practice SAT and ACT in the winter so you can choose your test.

THE ACT

Faster and more direct, with a science-reasoning section.

THE DIGITAL SAT

More time per question, and leans on reading and algebra.

Commit to one by spring and you walk into 11th with a plan instead of a question.

Your first AP exam in May is also a preview of testing under pressure. Take the prep seriously. A 4 or 5 is a real credential.

☐ BEFORE THE SEMESTER ENDS

For each main activity, finish this sentence: "This year I was the one who ____." If you can't fill the blank, you know what to do.

SUMMER #2: LAUNCH

This is the first summer colleges will really read about. The question it should answer: what happens when this student commits to something?

TYPE	WHAT MAKES IT COUNT
A job	Responsibility and hours. Training new hires or working 30 hrs/week says more than most programs.
A program	Selective, academic, in your lane. Free state-run programs (governor's schools, university research) often outrank pricey ones.
Research	Cold-email local professors and grad students with a short, specific ask. Expect 1 yes in 20. One is enough. (Script on **p. 63**.)
Own project	Something that exists by August: a published piece, a working app, a tutoring program with students, a business with revenue.
Service	Sustained beats scattered: 80 hours at one organization beats 8 hours at ten.

THE CONVERSATION TO HAVE WITH YOUR FAMILY

VISITS, BUT LOW-PRESSURE

Walk around a big state university, a small private college and a mid-sized school this spring or summer. No tours required. Come home with sentences like **"I liked how small the classes seemed"** or **"that felt too isolated."** Those become the filters for your list in 11th grade.

And briefly revisit the money conversation: has anything changed?

Jackson's note

The job row is the most underrated line on this page. A summer where people relied on you beats a summer where your parents paid for a lanyard.

AM I ON TRACK?

End-of-year check. Same rules as last year: no rounding up.

- [ ] My grades held steady or improved compared with 9th grade, in a harder schedule.
- [ ] I took (or will take next year) my first AP/IB course in a subject I'm strong in.
- [ ] My 11th-grade schedule is the most rigorous I can handle well, with all five core subjects.
- [ ] I've taken one timed practice SAT and one practice ACT and chosen which test I'll take.
- [ ] I took the practice PSAT and know which sections need work.
- [ ] I'm down to 2–3 main activities, and in at least one I have a specific responsibility.
- [ ] I can name a measurable thing I contributed this year (money raised, people reached, things built).
- [ ] I have a plan for this summer that involves sustained effort on one thing.
- [ ] There are two teachers who know my work well and whom I'd be comfortable asking for a letter.
- [ ] My brag sheet is up to date, and I've visited (even casually) at least two campuses.

8–10
On track.

5–7
Fix two this summer.

0–4
11th is still very recoverable. Make a plan with a counselor before August.

show this page to a parent. it's the easiest "how's school going" you'll ever have.

THE MISTAKES WE SEE MOST

Four sophomore-year classics, and what to do instead.

APS FOR OPTICS, IN SUBJECTS YOU DISLIKE

A B- in AP Chemistry because "it looks rigorous" costs you twice: the grade, and the hours you could have spent going deeper in something you actually care about.

DO INSTEAD → **Rigor in your strengths. Always.**

TEN CLUBS, ZERO RESPONSIBILITY

Colleges give you ten slots for activities and don't want them all filled.

DO INSTEAD → **Three activities where you clearly mattered beat ten where you showed up.**

STARTING SAT PREP NOW. OR NEVER THINKING ABOUT IT.

Months of prep in 10th grade burn students out before scores count. But skipping the diagnostic means entering junior year without knowing which test to take or how far you have to go.

DO INSTEAD → **Diagnose now. Prep later.**

LETTING SUMMER HAPPEN BY DEFAULT

The students who scramble in 11th grade are usually the ones whose 10th-grade summer was "nothing much." Program deadlines are in winter.

DO INSTEAD → **Decide in January, not June.**

That's 10th grade. One step up in rigor, one real responsibility, a test chosen, a summer with a center. Do that and junior year stops being scary and starts being a chance to show off what you've built.

11

PART 4 · YEAR 3

11TH GRADE: THE BIG YEAR

Junior year is the last full year colleges see before you apply, the year your recommenders get to know you, the year you test, and the year your list takes shape. It is a lot. The students who handle it well aren't smarter. They decided in August what the year was for.

Six goals for the year	38	Why it weighs the most	39
Choosing your APs	40	Month by month	41
Will teachers have something to write?	43	Activities & the testing plan	44
The summer before senior year	45	Drafting the list	46
Am I on track?	47	The mistakes we see most	48

decide in August what this year is for. then protect it.

9th BUILD · 10th DEEPEN · **11th PERFORM** · 12th EXECUTE

SIX GOALS FOR THE YEAR

Yes, six. Junior year earns it. Tape this page somewhere you'll see it.

1 **YOUR STRONGEST TRANSCRIPT YEAR**

The most rigorous schedule you can handle well, and your best grades yet. Readers look here hardest.

2 **TESTING DONE (OR NEARLY) BY JUNE**

First real SAT/ACT in spring, retake by June. Senior fall is the safety net, not the plan.

3 **REAL LEADERSHIP, WITH RESULTS**

Own something in 1–2 activities. Scale your project. Measure what changed.

4 **TWO RECOMMENDERS WHO KNOW YOU**

Junior-year teachers write the letters. Participate, go to office hours, ask by May.

5 **A DRAFTED COLLEGE LIST BY MAY**

20–25 schools researched, cut to 12–15 by August, with a real budget behind it.

6 **A SUMMER THAT CONNECTS TO YOUR STORY**

The experience you'd write about, plus essay draft #1 before senior year starts.

☐ NOW YOURS

My three goals this year, in my own words:

Jackson's note

Looks like a lot. It is. But notice that four of the six are things you've been quietly building since 9th grade. Junior year is mostly the year you cash in work you already did.

WHY JUNIOR YEAR CARRIES THE MOST WEIGHT

When you apply in the fall of 12th grade, your transcript shows three completed years. Of those, 11th is the most recent, the most rigorous, and the best predictor of how you'll do in college.

Readers know this. **A strong junior year can redeem a weak start. A weak junior year is hard to explain.**

It's also the year everything else gets built: test scores, recommendations (teachers who just taught you write the best letters), your leadership record, and your list. The calendar is dense because the year is.

THE SEQUENCING RULE

ANYTHING THAT CAN BE DONE BEFORE AUGUST OF SENIOR YEAR SHOULD BE.

Testing in winter and spring. The list and the essay in summer. Every task you finish in junior year is one fewer thing competing with your senior-year grades and your applications. **Senior fall should be about telling the story, not building it.**

GRADES: THE PROTECTION PLAN

With three or four APs, testing and leadership in one year, grades slip when students run out of *hours*, not ability. Protect them with structure:

FRONT-LOAD THE SEMESTER

The first six weeks set your grade's ceiling.

OFFICE HOURS AS DEFAULT

Every other week, whether you need it or not. It's also how teachers get to know you well enough to write a specific letter.

ONE HARD THING AT A TIME

Test prep in windows that don't overlap AP exams or finals.

KNOW THE DROP POLICY

Learn your school's rules in September, not in November.

CHOOSING APS FOR JUNIOR YEAR

Three or four APs is typical for students aiming at selective colleges. Two is plenty for most. The pattern matters more than the count.

IF YOU'RE LEANING TOWARD…	PRIORITIZE
STEM / engineering	AP Calculus (AB or BC), AP Physics or Chemistry, AP Computer Science A; language through level 4
Pre-med / life sciences	AP Biology, AP Chemistry, AP Calculus or Statistics, strong English
Business / economics	AP Calculus, AP Statistics, AP Micro/Macroeconomics, AP US History or Government
Humanities / social science	AP English Language, AP US History, AP Government or Psychology, language to level 4+, math through Precalculus or Statistics
Arts / design	AP Art & Design or Music Theory, AP English, plus the strongest academic core you can carry while building a portfolio
Undecided	One AP in each of two or three areas you like. Undecided is normal. Balanced rigor is the right answer.

RULE OF THUMB

EVERY AP SHOULD BE ONE YOU CAN EARN AN A OR B IN *AND* SCORE A 4 OR 5 ON.

If either looks unlikely, take the honors version. A B- in an AP you hate costs you twice.

☐ BEFORE COURSE SELECTION

Fill in the 11th and 12th-grade columns of Worksheet 1 (→ p. 76) and take it to your counselor. Walk in with a plan and the meeting takes ten minutes.

MONTH BY MONTH: AUGUST TO DECEMBER

AUG–SEP

SET THE YEAR

- Confirm your schedule. **Introduce yourself in week one to every teacher**, especially the two you'll want letters from.
- Set the testing plan (→ p. 58): which test, first date, when prep starts. Register for the PSAT/NMSQT through school.
- Take the leadership step you set up last spring. Start a results log: what you did, what changed, numbers.

OCT

PSAT/NMSQT

- **PSAT/NMSQT (Oct 1–30 window). This one counts.** It's the qualifying test for National Merit.
- Meet your counselor: share your senior course plan and ask how they write their letter. Make sure they know you.

NOV–DEC

FINALS + RESEARCH

- Finals. Protect these grades. They're the newest ones on your transcript when you apply early.
- PSAT scores land in December. Use the breakdown to set prep targets.
- **Over break: build a research spreadsheet of 20–25 colleges** (→ p. 80). Criteria first, then schools.

Why "introduce yourself in week one" is on the list

The two teachers you meet this August are probably writing your recommendation letters. They can only write about the student they saw. Give them something to see from the first week: a question, a visit to office hours, a face they connect to a name.

☐ FIRST WEEK OF SCHOOL

Pick your two. Ideally one STEM teacher and one humanities teacher. Write their names here: _____ and _____.

MONTH BY MONTH: JANUARY TO SUMMER

JAN–FEB

PREP + SELECT

- **Test prep begins, 8–12 weeks before your first test:** timed sections, an error log, one full practice test every two weeks.
- Register: SAT March 6 (deadline Feb 19) or ACT Feb 27 / Apr 10.
- Course selection for 12th grade. Keep five cores and your rigor. Colleges see your senior schedule and mid-year grades. Summer program applications are due now too.

MAR

FIRST TEST

- **SAT March 6, 2027.** Scores in about two weeks. Decide right away whether you'll retake May 1 or June 5.
- Spring break: visit 3–5 colleges from your spreadsheet. Take the official tour.

APR–MAY

APS + THE ASK

- ACT April 10. SAT retake May 1 (deadline Apr 16). AP exams May 3–14.
- **Ask two teachers for recommendations before the end of May.** Ask in person, then follow up with your brag sheet.
- Cut the list toward 12–15 schools. Run every net price calculator with your parents (→ p. 72).

JUN

LAST TESTS

- SAT June 5 / ACT June 12 if you still need a retake. Finals. Update the brag sheet.
- Create your Common App account and read the personal-statement prompts.

SUMMER

PROVE

- The summer that connects to your story (→ p. 45). **Essay draft #1 by mid-July.** List finalized. ACT July 10 if needed.

put "ask for recs" in your calendar for May 1. right now. I'll wait.

WILL YOUR TEACHERS HAVE SOMETHING TO WRITE?

You're asking two teachers for letters in May. Check in October whether they'd have anything specific to say. If the answer is "not yet," you have seven months to fix it.

FOR EACH OF YOUR TWO TEACHERS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2
I speak up in their class most weeks. A question or a comment, not just attendance.	☐	☐
I've been to their office hours at least twice this semester.	☐	☐
They've seen my best work, and I can name the specific piece.	☐	☐
They've watched me struggle with something and come back from it.	☐	☐
They know one thing about me outside their class: an activity, a project, what I want to study.	☐	☐

4–5
They can write a specific letter. Keep showing up.

2–3
Pick the two unchecked rows and work on them this semester.

0–1
Either invest here now, or consider a different teacher.

THREE MOVES THAT CHANGE THE LETTER

1. **Go to office hours with a real question,** not a grade complaint. Something from the reading you kept thinking about.
2. **Do one piece of work past the requirement** in their class, and tell them why you did.
3. **When you get something wrong, go back.** A teacher who watched you fix a weak paper has a story to tell. One who only saw your A's has a grade to report.

The ask itself, and what to hand them, is on **p. 69**.

ACTIVITIES: OWN SOMETHING

Leadership isn't a title. It's ownership.

TELLS A READER NOTHING

"Vice President of Key Club"

→

TELLS THEM EVERYTHING

"ORGANIZED A 40-VOLUNTEER TUTORING PROGRAM SERVING 60 MIDDLE-SCHOOLERS WEEKLY"

- **Scale what you planted.** More people, more output, a second location, a partner organization.
- **Hold a real role** (captain, editor, section leader, president) and do the job, not just hold it.
- **Keep a results log.** Monthly: what you did, what changed, numbers.
- **Go outside school.** Local organizations, competitions, publications and jobs show you can operate in the adult world.

THE TESTING PLAN, JUNIOR YEAR

WHEN	SAT PATH	ACT PATH
Oct	PSAT/NMSQT (counts for National Merit)	
Jan–Feb	8–12 weeks of prep	
First test	Mar 6, 2027	Feb 27 or Apr 10, 2027
Retake	May 1 or Jun 5	Jun 12 or Jul 10
Safety net	Senior fall: Aug 28 / Sep 18 / Oct 2, 2027 (anticipated)	Senior fall: Sep and Oct 2027 (dates not yet announced)

Registration deadlines are roughly 2–5 weeks before each date. Full details, the prep plan and policy notes are on **p. 58**.

THE SUMMER BEFORE SENIOR YEAR

This summer has two jobs: be the experience you'd write about, and clear the runway for senior fall.

JOB 1

The "prove it" experience

Go further down your lane than you ever have, in a way that produces something concrete:

- Research that ends in a poster, paper or presentation
- A project that reaches a new scale
- Work with real responsibility in a field you might study
- A selective program in your lane
- Service with depth: a role you designed, a problem you solved

The test: can you describe it in one sentence with a number and a verb? "I built..." "I ran..." "I published..."

JOB 2

Clear the runway

- [ ] Personal statement draft #1 by mid-July
- [ ] Final list of 12–15 with 3+ likelies you'd attend
- [ ] Net price calculator run for every school
- [ ] Activities list drafted (10 × 150 characters)
- [ ] Brag sheet sent to both recommenders
- [ ] Every supplement and deadline in one spreadsheet
- [ ] Visit your top 3–5; decide on Early Decision with your parents

STUDENTS WHO DO BOTH JOBS APPLY FROM A POSITION OF CALM.

Students who do neither write essays in October while studying for AP Calculus. The difference in senior-year grades, and in the essays, is visible to readers.

Jackson's note

Draft #1 only has to exist. It's allowed to be terrible. A bad draft in July beats a perfect idea in October every single time.

DRAFTING THE LIST: A FIRST PASS

Twelve to fifteen schools, balanced across odds, every one of them a place you'd be glad to go.

3–4 **LIKELY**

Your GPA and scores sit at or above the top of their middle-50% range, and they admit most applicants. You'd be happy to attend. If you wouldn't, it isn't a likely. It's a wasted application.

4–6 **TARGET**

You're squarely in their middle 50% and their admit rate is above about 30%. These should be the heart of the list: the schools you're most likely to actually attend.

3–5 **REACH**

Below their middle 50%, or any school admitting under 20% regardless of your stats. Nobody is a "likely" at a 7%-admit school. Apply to the ones you love. Don't stack the list with them.

Jackson's note

I went through four counselors before one got me. The first three weren't bad. They were wrong for me. Colleges work the same way. A school that's "better" by ranking but wrong for you will get less out of you than the one that fits. **Build the list from who you are, and let the rankings be a tiebreaker, not the filter.**

Financial fit is a category, not an afterthought

Run every school's net price calculator with real family numbers. A school you can't afford isn't on the list. It's a reach in a different sense. The full method starts on p. 65.

AM I ON TRACK?

Check in June. Then check again in August, because summer has a way of moving things.

- [ ] Junior year is my strongest transcript year: hardest schedule so far, best grades.
- [ ] I've taken the SAT or ACT at least once and know whether I'm retaking (and when).
- [ ] My senior schedule keeps five core subjects and my current level of rigor.
- [ ] I hold a real role in at least one activity, and I can state what changed because of me, with numbers.
- [ ] The project I started has grown this year.
- [ ] Two teachers have agreed to write my recommendations and have my brag sheet.
- [ ] I have a list of 12–15 schools with 3+ likelies I'd happily attend.
- [ ] My family has run net price calculators and we've agreed on a budget.
- [ ] I have a personal-statement draft (any quality) before August.
- [ ] I know every supplemental essay and deadline on my list, in one place.

8–10
Senior fall will be about applications, not catch-up.

6–7
Use the summer runway list deliberately.

0–5
Talk to a counselor this summer, not in September.

"any quality" is doing a lot of work in box 9. that's on purpose.

THE MISTAKES WE SEE MOST

Four junior-year mistakes that don't show up until senior fall, when they're expensive to fix.

TESTING FOR THE FIRST TIME IN SENIOR FALL

It leaves no room for a retake before early deadlines, and it collides with applications and the hardest classes of senior year.

DO INSTEAD → **Spring of 11th is the first test. Senior fall is the backup.**

ASKING FOR RECOMMENDATIONS IN SEPTEMBER

By then, popular teachers have a waitlist and 40 letters to write.

DO INSTEAD → **Ask in May, with a brag sheet. You get a thoughtful letter from a teacher who just taught you.**

BUILDING THE LIST FROM RANKINGS

"Top 20" is not a fit criterion. Size, program strength, location, culture and cost are. A list built on rankings produces too many reaches, too few likelies you'd attend, and a bad April.

DO INSTEAD → **Criteria first, then names (p. 65).**

DROPPING RIGOR FOR SENIOR YEAR

Colleges see your senior courses on the application and your first-semester grades in February. A schedule that goes from four APs to study hall raises exactly the question you don't want raised.

DO INSTEAD → **Keep five cores. Keep the level.**

That's 11th grade. The hardest year, and the one where everything you've built starts to count. If you finish it with the runway cleared, senior year is just telling people what you already did.

12

PART 5 · YEAR 4

12TH GRADE: EXECUTE

Senior year is a project-management problem with an emotional component. The work is mostly done. Now it has to be told well, submitted on time, and paid for. The students who come through it well treat every deadline as a week earlier than printed, and they keep showing up to class.

Four goals for the year	50	The application, piece by piece	51
Month by month	52	Decision plans, explained	55
The mistakes we see most	56	Essays → the Toolkit	67

every deadline is one week earlier than it says. trust me.

FOUR GOALS FOR THE YEAR

The building is done. This year is about finishing: telling it well, on time, at a price your family can live with.

1 **SUBMIT EVERY APPLICATION A WEEK EARLY.**

Portals crash on deadline night. Early submission also leaves time to fix the thing you will inevitably notice.

2 **KEEP THE GRADES.**

Mid-year reports go out in February. Admitted students have offers rescinded over senior slides every year.

3 **TELL THE STORY WELL.**

Personal statement, supplements, activities list and recommendations should read as one coherent person.

4 **GET THE MONEY RIGHT.**

FAFSA and CSS Profile in October. Compare real award letters in April. Appeal if the numbers don't work.

WHERE TO PUT YOUR ENERGY

THE PERSONAL STATEMENT, AND THE "WHY US?" SUPPLEMENTS FOR YOUR TOP FIVE SCHOOLS.

Those are the pieces read most closely that you still control. Grades, scores and activities are largely set by September. Your only job there is to not let them slip.

☐ NOW YOURS

My three goals this year, in my own words:

Starting this guide as a senior? Skip the guilt, go straight to the calendar on **p. 52**, and start from today's date.

THE APPLICATION, PIECE BY PIECE

Nine components. Four of them come from other people, which is why the asking happened in May.

COMPONENT	WHO PROVIDES IT	YOUR JOB
Common App / Coalition / school app	You	Profile, family, education, activities (10 slots), honors (5), personal statement
Supplements	You	School-specific essays, short answers, "Why us?", choice of major
Transcript + school report	Counselor	Request early. Your school's internal deadline is often 2+ weeks before the college's.
Counselor letter	Counselor	Make sure they know you. Give them your brag sheet.
Teacher letters (usually 2)	Teachers	Asked in May. Gentle reminder 3 weeks before the first deadline. Thank them.
Test scores	College Board / ACT	Send official scores where required; self-report where allowed. Allow 1–2 weeks.
Mid-year report	Counselor	Automatic in February. Keep the grades up.
FAFSA / CSS Profile	You + parents	File in October. Check each school's priority deadline.
Portfolio / audition / interview	You	Only for some programs. Deadlines are often earlier than the application's.

☐ FIRST WEEK OF AUGUST

Build the master spreadsheet: every school, plan (ED/EA/RD), date, supplements, test policy, aid deadline. One tab. One source of truth. Everything on the next three pages plugs into it.

MONTH BY MONTH: AUGUST TO OCTOBER

AUG

OPEN

- **Aug 1: Common App opens.** Roll over your account. Complete every non-essay section in the first two weeks.
- Personal statement: draft #1 → #2 → #3. Read it aloud. Get one trusted adult's feedback (not five).
- SAT Aug 22 if you're retaking. Confirm your recommenders in the first week of school and re-send the brag sheet.

SEP

WRITE

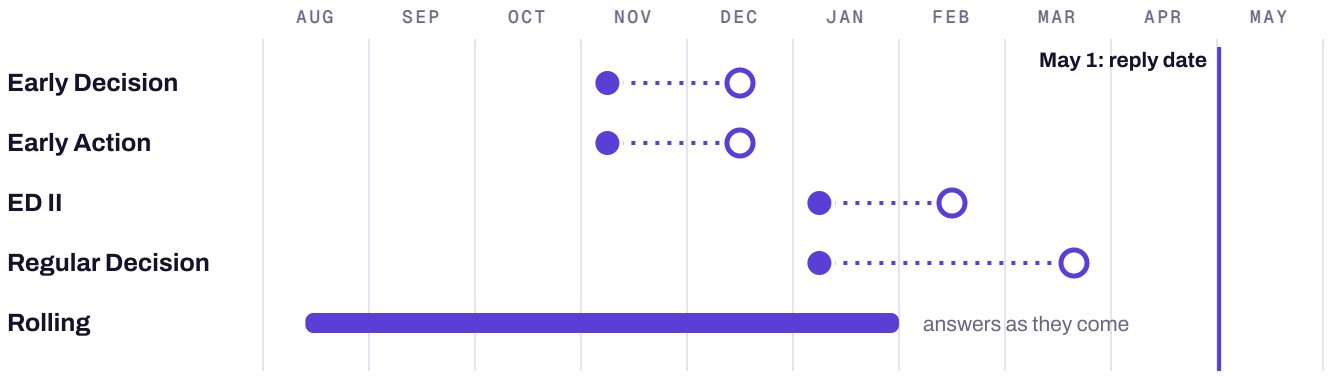
- **Supplements for your early schools first, then the rest.** Generic "Why us?" answers are the most common weakness in otherwise strong applications (→ p. 68).
- SAT Sep 12 / ACT Sep 19 if needed. Meet your counselor: confirm the school's internal deadline for transcripts and letters.
- Some early deadlines are Oct 15 (UNC, UGA, Georgia Tech and others). Finish those this month.
- Parents: gather 2025 tax returns and current account balances for aid forms.

OCT

EARLY + AID

- SAT Oct 3 / ACT Oct 17: the last dates most early-plan schools accept.
- **FAFSA and CSS Profile are live by Oct 1** (the 2027–28 FAFSA opened in late September this year). File both in October. Many priority aid deadlines match ED/EA dates.
- **Submit ED/EA applications by about Oct 25** for Nov 1 deadlines. Confirm every portal shows "complete."
- Send official test scores where required (allow 1–2 weeks).

WHEN YOU APPLY, AND WHEN YOU HEAR BACK



● Apply by ○ Hear back (typical; ED II about mid-February)

Dates are for the 2026–27 cycle. In a later year the months hold and the exact days shift, so confirm before you register or submit.

MONTH BY MONTH: NOVEMBER TO JANUARY

NOV

DEADLINES

- **Nov 1 and Nov 15: the big ED/EA deadlines.** SAT Nov 7 is the last date some schools accept for early plans. Check.
- University of California and Cal State applications are due in early December (UC has recently used Dec 1 or Dec 2; confirm). UC uses four Personal Insight Questions in place of a personal statement.
- Rolling-admission schools: apply now. Earlier applications get decisions (and sometimes merit money) sooner.
- Keep working on regular-decision supplements. Don't wait for early results.

DEC

RESULTS + RD

- **ED/EA decisions arrive mid-December.** If admitted ED: withdraw all other applications. It's binding. If deferred or denied: finish RD applications. You planned for this.
- SAT Dec 5 / ACT Dec 12: the last dates for most Jan 1 regular deadlines.
- Finals. First-semester grades go to colleges in the mid-year report. This is not the semester to slide.
- Submit Jan 1 applications before winter break.

JAN

RD + ED II

- Regular-decision deadlines cluster Jan 1–15. ED II (a second binding round) is usually Jan 1–15 too.
- Check every portal for missing items. **Colleges email. Students don't read email. Read email.**
- Scholarship season: local and national deadlines run Jan–Mar. Local ones have far better odds.

IF DECEMBER BRINGS A DEFERRAL OR A DENIAL

It stings. Let it, for a day. Then remember the list was built for exactly this: targets and likelies you'd be glad to attend. One school's answer is not a verdict on you. It's one reader, one pile, one year. Finish the RD applications. **You planned for this.**

MONTH BY MONTH: FEBRUARY TO JULY

FEB

MID-YEAR

- Your counselor sends the mid-year report with first-semester grades. Confirm it went.
- Interviews, if offered. Prepare three stories and two real questions.
- Start a comparison sheet as EA and rolling decisions arrive: cost of attendance, grants, loans, net price.

MAR

DECISIONS

- Most RD decisions land mid-to-late March. Expect a mix. That's what the list was built for.
- **Compare net price** (cost minus grants and scholarships), not sticker price or "total aid," which often includes loans.
- Waitlisted somewhere you love? Accept the spot and send one concise letter of continued interest. Then deposit elsewhere.

APR

DECIDE

- Admitted-student days. Visit your top 2–3 if you can.
- Appeal financial aid if circumstances changed or another school's offer is better (→ p. 72).
- Decide with the budget in front of you. Four years of debt is a real cost. So is a school you'll be unhappy at.

MAY

COMMIT

- **May 1: National Candidates Reply Date.** Deposit at one school. Decline the others promptly.
- AP exams May 3–14. Scores (July) can earn credit and placement.

JUN–JUL

FINISH

- Final transcript sent by your counselor. Housing, orientation, placement tests and health forms all have summer deadlines.
- **Thank the people who wrote your letters, in writing.** Then rest. You earned it.

then go hug whoever drove you to all those campus visits.

DECISION PLANS, EXPLAINED

How you apply matters almost as much as where. Early plans often carry higher admit rates, but the binding ones take away your ability to compare financial offers.

PLAN	DEADLINE	BINDING?	BEST FOR
Early Decision (ED)	Nov 1 or 15	Yes	A clear first choice you've visited, and a family that has run the net price calculator and can afford the result
ED II	Jan 1–15	Yes	Students denied or deferred in ED I with a strong second choice
Early Action (EA)	Nov 1 or 15 (some Oct 15)	No	Almost everyone: earlier answers, no commitment, sometimes earlier merit aid
Restrictive / Single-Choice EA	Nov 1	No, but restricts other private early apps	A top choice among the few that offer it (Harvard, Yale, Princeton, Stanford, Notre Dame, Georgetown)
Regular Decision (RD)	Jan 1–15	No	Everyone; the bulk of most lists
Rolling	Opens Aug–Sep	No	Many public universities; apply early for the best odds and merit money

THE ED TEST

WOULD YOU STILL SAY YES IF YOU GOT IN AND THE AID CAME BACK EXACTLY AS THE NET PRICE CALCULATOR PREDICTED, WITH NO CHANCE TO COMPARE?

If the truthful answer is "I'd want to see other offers," apply EA or RD. **ED is a commitment, not a strategy.**

THE MISTAKES WE SEE MOST

Four senior-year mistakes. All of them avoidable. All of them made every year by smart people.

SUBMITTING AT 11:58 P.M.

Portals slow down, payments fail, and you spot the wrong school's name in a "Why us?" essay with two minutes left.

DO INSTEAD → **A week early. Every time.**

THE SENIOR SLIDE

Colleges request final transcripts and can rescind offers. A drop from A's to C's, a dropped AP without notice, or a disciplinary issue costs students their spot every year.

DO INSTEAD → **Finish the year you started. Tell colleges before you change your schedule.**

IGNORING THE PORTALS (AND EMAIL)

Missing a document notice in November can mean an incomplete application in December.

DO INSTEAD → **Check every portal weekly through January, and read every college email.**

COMPARING STICKER PRICES, OR "AID" TOTALS

A $45,000 "award" that's $30,000 in loans is a $15,000 award.

DO INSTEAD → **Compare net price after grants and scholarships only, for all four years, against the budget your family set in 11th grade.**

That's the four years. Build, deepen, perform, execute. The rest of this guide is the toolkit behind the calendar: the frameworks for each piece, in the order you'll need them.

06

PART 6

THE TOOLKIT

The frameworks behind the calendar: how to choose a test, how activities turn into impact, how to plan four summers, how to build a list you'll be glad you built, how to write the essays, and how to pay for it.

SAT vs. ACT, dates, prep	58	The activities ladder	60
Impact: the three numbers	61	The four summers	62
Building toward a major	64	Building the college list	65
The personal statement	67	"Why us?" supplements	68
Recommendations	69	The activities list	70
FAFSA, CSS & award letters	71	Reading an award letter	72

don't read this part in order. come here when the calendar sends you.

SAT VS. ACT: CHOOSING YOUR TEST

Colleges accept both equally. Take one full-length, timed practice test of each in the winter of 10th grade, convert both to percentiles, and pick the higher one. If they're close, use this:

	DIGITAL SAT	ACT
Length	About 2h 14m; two sections (Reading & Writing, Math)	About 2h 5m core (English, Math, Reading); Science optional since 2025
Pace	More time per question; adaptive modules	Fast. That's the main challenge for many students.
Reading	Short passages, one question each	Longer passages, several questions each
Math	Calculator throughout (built in); heavier on algebra	Broader (more geometry and trig); calculator allowed
Suits	Careful readers; students who like more time	Fast workers; students who prefer direct questions
Scores	400–1600	1–36 composite

WHEN TO STOP TESTING

STOP IF

Your score is at or above the middle 50% of your reach schools (published on every college's admissions page).

STOP IF

Two retakes haven't moved it more than a few points.

STOP IF

You've reached three sittings. Past that, the hours are worth more elsewhere.

Most colleges superscore the SAT (best section scores across dates) and many superscore the ACT. Check each school.

DATES, A PREP PLAN, AND WHO REQUIRES SCORES

2026–27 test dates

SAT	ACT
Aug 22, 2026	Sep 19, 2026
Sep 12, 2026	Oct 17, 2026
Oct 3, 2026	Dec 12, 2026
Nov 7, 2026	Feb 27, 2027
Dec 5, 2026	Apr 10, 2027
Mar 6, 2027	Jun 12, 2027
May 1, 2027	Jul 10, 2027
Jun 5, 2027	

SAT registration closes about 2 weeks before each date; ACT about 5 weeks. PSAT/NMSQT: Oct 1–30, 2026. PSAT 10: Mar 1–Apr 30, 2027. AP exams: May 3–14, 2027. Confirm at satsuite.collegeboard.org and act.org.

A prep plan that works

- **8–12 weeks before the test,** 4–6 hours a week.
- **Official materials first:** Bluebook for the SAT; ACT's official guide and free tests.
- **An error log.** Every missed question, why you missed it, and the rule you needed. Review weekly. This is where scores move.
- **One full timed test every two weeks.** Sections alone don't build stamina.
- **Tutoring helps for a specific gap.** It can't replace the hours.

SHOULD I EVEN TEST?

YES. PLAN TO HAVE A SCORE.

About 93% of four-year colleges with confirmed policies are test-optional or test-free for this cycle (FairTest). But the top of the list has swung back: six of the eight Ivy League schools require scores now, and Princeton and Columbia will starting with the 2027–28 cycle. MIT, Stanford, Caltech and Georgetown require them, along with public systems in Florida, Georgia and Texas.

A good score opens doors everywhere. A missing one closes doors you may want open in a year. Verify every school on your list each fall. Policies change.

the error log is boring. it's also the whole secret.

THE ACTIVITIES LADDER

Colleges aren't counting your activities. They're asking one question about each: how far up did this student climb?

1 · Participate

You showed up. Member, player, volunteer. Where everything starts.

2 · Contribute

You did a specific job others relied on. Ran the social media, kept the books, trained new members.

3 · Lead

You were responsible for outcomes. Captain, editor, president. Other people's results depended on your decisions.

4 · Create

You made something exist that didn't before (a program, a publication, a business, research) with results you can measure.

HOW TO CLIMB

9th	Rung 1 in several places. Notice which one you'd do for free.
10th	Rung 2 in 2–3 places. Volunteer for the job nobody wants.
11th	Rung 3 in one or two. Plant something at Rung 4.
12th	Sustain Rung 3–4 and document the results.

You do not need Rung 4 to get into a good college.

You need a visible, truthful climb. And at the most selective schools, at least one activity at Rung 3 or 4 that is clearly yours.

IMPACT: THE THREE NUMBERS

For each main activity, know three numbers. They turn a title into evidence.

NUMBER	EXAMPLES
Scale	People served, members, attendees, readers, users, students tutored
Output	Dollars raised, events run, articles published, hours delivered, products shipped
Change	Growth (from 12 members to 40), a result (placed 3rd at state), a before/after (test scores up 15%)

BEFORE

"Vice President, Environmental Club."

→

AFTER

"LED 25-MEMBER CLUB; LAUNCHED CAMPUS COMPOSTING PROGRAM DIVERTING ~400 LBS/MONTH; SECURED $1,200 DISTRICT GRANT."

DEPTH, NOT BREADTH

Two or three activities with a four-year arc beat eight with a one-year stint. The activities list has 10 slots. Readers do not expect them all filled, and a list of ten one-year memberships signals exactly what it is.

Activities that count more than students think

Paid work. Family responsibilities: caring for siblings, translating for parents, working in a family business. **A serious independent pursuit** with an audience or a record. If it took real time and you grew in it, it belongs on the list.

RIGHT NOW

Pick your main activity and write its three numbers in the margin. Missing one? That's your goal for the semester. Then log it on Worksheet 2 (→ p. 77).

THE FOUR SUMMERS

Summers are a third of your high-school time and the only part you fully control. Each one has a job.

	AFTER 9TH · EXPLORE	AFTER 10TH · LAUNCH	AFTER 11TH · PROVE
The question	**What am I curious about?**	**What happens when I commit?**	**What have I actually done?**
Good shape	A job + one deep-dive interest + a lot of reading	One substantial thing for 6–8 weeks	Further down your lane, producing something concrete, plus the senior-year runway
Deadlines	Few. Local programs fill by May.	Selective programs: Jan–Mar	Selective programs: Dec–Feb. Research outreach: Jan–Mar.
Cost	Close to free	Free and state programs are often more respected than paid ones	Spend only if it's the real thing in your field
Avoid	Nothing by default; expensive "pre-college" tourism	Scattered short stints; prestige outside your interests	Starting essays in September; a summer with nothing to write about

AND THE FOURTH ONE

THE SUMMER AFTER SENIOR YEAR BELONGS TO YOU.

Orientation, housing forms, placement tests and AP scores (early July) have deadlines, so put them on a calendar in May. Otherwise, rest. You've been running a four-year project. **Let it end.**

Plan all of them on Worksheet 3 (→ **p. 78**).

TWO UNDERRATED SUMMER OPTIONS

How to get research as a high schooler

1. Read 2–3 recent papers from a local professor or lab whose work you can follow.
2. Email the professor *and* a grad student or postdoc. Four short paragraphs: who you are, what you read and found interesting, what you can offer (hours, skills), a specific ask.
3. Send 20. Expect 1–2 replies. Follow up once after 10 days.
4. Community colleges and smaller universities say yes more often than famous ones.

The self-directed project

It costs nothing, needs no acceptance letter, and ends with something that's entirely yours. Three rules:

- **It solves a real problem for real people:** a tutoring program, a tool, a publication, a service.
- **It exists by August:** public, usable, with a few real users or participants.
- **It has numbers you can report,** and a plan to continue during the school year.

THE EMAIL THAT GETS A REPLY

Subject: High school junior interested in [specific topic from their paper]

Dear Professor [Name], I'm a junior at [school]. I read your 2025 paper on [specific thing] and was struck by [one specific observation or question, and mean it].

I've [relevant thing you've done: a class, a project, a skill like Python or lab experience]. I'd love to help with [specific kind of task] this summer. I can commit [X] hours a week from [dates] and work remotely or on site.

I understand you're busy; if someone in your lab would be a better contact, I'd be grateful for the introduction. Thank you for your time. — [Name, phone]

19 people ignoring you is the cost of the 1 who says yes. send the 20.

BUILDING TOWARD A MAJOR

You don't need to know your major at 15. You need a direction a reader can see. And at some colleges, the major you write down changes your odds, so it's worth knowing which ones.

HOW A DIRECTION SHOWS UP

CLASSES

Your hardest courses lean toward it (→ p. 40).

ONE ACTIVITY

Something you climbed in that connects to it (→ p. 60).

ONE SUMMER

A job, project or program in that area (→ p. 62).

YOUR WRITING

An essay or "Why us?" that explains where the interest came from.

Three of the four is plenty. All four pointing at one thing you don't care about is worse than two pointing at something you do.

WHERE THE MAJOR YOU LIST MATTERS

HOW THE COLLEGE ADMITS	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU
To the college as a whole	Common at liberal arts colleges and some universities. "Undecided" is fine, and you usually declare by the end of sophomore year.
By school or by major	Common at large universities. Popular programs such as engineering, computer science, nursing and business often have limited seats, so they can be harder to get into than the university overall.
Direct-admit or specialized programs	Some programs (nursing, architecture, arts with a portfolio or audition) admit you straight into the program, often with extra requirements and earlier deadlines.

TWO QUESTIONS TO ASK EVERY SCHOOL ON YOUR LIST

"DO YOU ADMIT BY MAJOR?" AND "HOW HARD IS IT TO SWITCH INTO THE ONE I WANT LATER?"

Listing an easier major and planning to switch can backfire: moving into a limited-seat program after you enroll is often competitive, and sometimes not possible. Each college publishes its own rules, so check theirs.

BUILDING THE COLLEGE LIST

A good list is 12–15 schools you'd be glad to attend, balanced across odds, and affordable. Build it from criteria, not rankings.

STEP 1

CRITERIA BEFORE NAMES

Program	Does it have, and is it good at, what you might study? Can you switch majors easily?
Size & setting	2,000 or 40,000 students? Urban, suburban, rural? You learned this on your 10th-grade visits.
Distance	Flight or drive? Be real with yourself about how often you'll want to be home.
Cost	Net price from the calculator, against the family budget. Merit aid policies matter here.
Culture	Greek life, sports, collaborative vs. competitive, political climate, religious affiliation.
Outcomes	Graduation rate, what graduates do, support for internships and research.

STEP 2

RESEARCH 20–25, VISIT WHAT YOU CAN

Use the college's own site, its **Common Data Set** (search "[college] common data set" for admit rates, middle-50% scores and aid data), and student-run sources for culture. Visit your top 5–8. Attend a virtual session for the rest. At schools that track demonstrated interest, it counts.

Jackson's note

Write your criteria down *before* you type a single school name. Once a famous name is on the list, it's very hard to be objective about it. I've watched it happen.

SORT BY ODDS, THEN BY MONEY

STEP 3

SORT BY ODDS, WITHOUT FLATTERING YOURSELF

CATEGORY	YOU ARE…	HOW MANY
Likely	Above their middle 50% (GPA and scores) and they admit most applicants. And you'd be happy there.	3–4
Target	Inside their middle 50%, admit rate above about 30%	4–6
Reach	Below their middle 50%, or admit rate under about 20% regardless of your stats	3–5

AN EXAMPLE LIST OF 13



Likely 3–4 schools **Target** 4–6 schools **Reach** 3–5 schools

"Middle 50%" is the range between the 25th and 75th percentile of admitted students. Every college publishes it.

STEP 4

FINANCIAL FIT FOR EVERY SCHOOL

Run each school's net price calculator with real numbers. Then sort every school into one of three piles:

Affordable as-is
Stays on the list.

Affordable with likely merit aid
Stays, with eyes open.

Not affordable
Comes off, unless the family agrees it's worth the stretch.

Make that third call **before you fall in love with the school.** Not after.

Five signs of a bad list

- [ ] More reaches than targets and likelies combined
- [ ] Likelies you'd be disappointed to attend
- [ ] Every school is the same type
- [ ] Nobody has run a net price calculator
- [ ] Built from a ranking instead of from you

Build yours on Worksheet 5 (→ p. 80).

THE PERSONAL STATEMENT

650 words, one of seven Common App prompts. (The last one is "topic of your choice," so the prompt barely matters.) It's the one place a reader hears your voice unfiltered.

Its job is **not** to list accomplishments. The rest of the application does that. Its job is to make a stranger feel like they know a real person, and would want that person around.

What works

- **Small and specific beats big and general.** One afternoon, one conversation, one object, told closely.
- **Reflection over narration.** A third is what happened; two-thirds is what you made of it.
- **Your actual voice.** Read it aloud. Cut anything you'd never say.
- **A quality the rest of the application can't show:** curiosity, humor, resilience, how you think.

What to avoid

- The résumé in paragraph form
- The sports injury / big game / mission trip essay, unless yours is truly different
- Writing about someone else so much that you disappear
- Thesaurus vocabulary and a dramatic opening you'd never say
- Letting a parent (or an AI) rewrite it until it isn't yours. Readers can tell.

Jackson's note

Same kid, same story, four counselors. The fourth one got me into a top-20 school because he knew how to tell it. The story was always there. If you're stuck, the problem is almost never that you have nothing to say. It's that you haven't noticed the thing yet. Do the "three things no one else at your school could say" exercise on p. 16. Start there.

THE TEST FOR A FINISHED DRAFT

If a reader couldn't tell it from a classmate's essay, it isn't done. **If your best friend would say "that sounds exactly like you," it is.**

THE PROCESS, AND THE "WHY US?" METHOD

THE PROCESS (SUMMER BEFORE SENIOR YEAR)

1. **BRAINSTORM (1 WEEK)**
   List 20 moments that changed how you think. Not achievements. Moments. Pick three and freewrite a page on each.

2. **DRAFT #1 (1 WEEK)**
   Pick the one you kept thinking about. Write it badly and long (900+ words). Don't edit.

3. **DRAFTS #2–3 (2–3 WEEKS)**
   Cut to 650. Push the reflection. Make every paragraph earn its place.

4. **ONE READER, THEN DONE**
   One trusted adult for feedback. Five sets of edits produce a committee essay.

"WHY US?" SUPPLEMENTS

The most common weakness in strong applications is a generic "Why us?": rankings, weather, "world-class faculty." Do this instead:

- **Name 3–4 specific things you can only get there** (a course, a professor's research, a program, a tradition) and say what you'd do with each.
- **Connect each to something you've already done.** "I built X; your Y program would let me Z."
- **Half you, half them.** If a paragraph could be about any school, cut it.
- **Check the school's name in every supplement before you submit.** Yes, people send one school's essay to another with the name still in it. Every year.

write it badly first. you can't edit a blank page.

RECOMMENDATIONS: WHO AND HOW

Most colleges want one counselor letter and one or two teacher letters. Teacher letters carry weight at selective schools because they answer the question grades can't: what is this student like in a room?

Who to ask

- **Junior-year teachers in core academic subjects.** They taught you most recently, at your most rigorous level.
- **Two different areas if possible** (one STEM, one humanities), unless you're applying to a specialized program.
- **The teacher who saw you work,** not necessarily the one who gave you the highest grade.

How to ask

- **In person, by May of junior year.**
- **Follow up with your brag sheet** (→ p. 79).
- **Submit requests in the Common App in August.** Remind gently three weeks before the first deadline.
- **Waive your right to view the letter (FERPA).** Colleges trust waived letters more.
- **Thank them** in writing, and again in spring with the result.

THE EXACT WORDS

"WOULD YOU FEEL COMFORTABLE WRITING ME A STRONG RECOMMENDATION?"

That phrasing gives the teacher a graceful way out. Which is what you want. A lukewarm letter from someone who felt cornered is worse than no letter from them at all.

A B+ in a class where you grew visibly, asked for help, and came back stronger often produces a better letter than an easy A. **Teachers write about who you became, not what you got.**

THE ACTIVITIES LIST: 10 SLOTS, 150 CHARACTERS

For each activity, the Common App asks for: type, position or title (50 characters), organization (100), description (150), grades participated, timing, hours per week, weeks per year, and whether you'll continue in college.

RULES FOR THE 150 CHARACTERS

1. **Lead with a verb.** Led, built, organized, launched, trained, raised, published, designed.
2. **Numbers in every entry** where you have them: the three numbers from **p. 61**.
3. **Fragments, not sentences.** Semicolons; no "I." Every character carries weight.
4. **Order by importance to you,** not chronology. Slot 1 is read most closely.
5. **Don't pad.** Seven strong entries beat ten with filler.

EXAMPLE · 148 CHARACTERS

FOUNDED PEER-TUTORING PROGRAM; RECRUITED & TRAINED 18 TUTORS; 60+ STUDENTS/WK; AVG. MATH GRADE UP ONE LETTER; EXPANDED TO 2ND SCHOOL YR 2

Honors section (5 slots, 100 characters)

Academic honors only: National Merit recognition, AP Scholar, honor roll, subject awards, competition placements, selective program admissions. Mark the level (school / state / national). Don't list activities here.

If you've kept Worksheet 2 up to date (→ **p. 77**), this page takes you one afternoon. If you haven't, it takes a week of trying to remember sophomore year.

FAFSA AND CSS PROFILE

Two forms. Both open in the fall of senior year. Both matter more than most families expect.

	FAFSA	CSS PROFILE
What	Federal form; determines eligibility for federal grants, loans and work-study; used by all colleges and most states	College Board form; used by about 200 mostly private colleges to award their own institutional aid
Opens	By Oct 1 of senior year (the 2027–28 form opened in late September 2026)	Oct 1 of senior year
Cost	Free at studentaid.gov	$25 first school, $16 each additional; fee waivers for lower-income families
Uses	Tax info from two years prior	Same, plus home equity, business assets, more detail
File	**In October.** Check each school's priority deadline. It often matches the ED/EA date.	

FILE EVEN IF YOU THINK YOU WON'T QUALIFY.

Many merit scholarships require a FAFSA on file, and the Student Aid Index surprises families in both directions.

NEED VS. MERIT

NEED-BASED AID

Depends on family finances. The most selective schools offer only this, often generously (many meet 100% of demonstrated need).

MERIT AID

Rewards grades and scores regardless of income. Most common at schools where you're above their middle 50%.

one more reason to love your likelies.

READING AN AWARD LETTER

Award letters are formatted to look generous. Rebuild each one the same way, and the real number shows up.

Cost of attendance	Tuition + fees + housing + food + books + travel + personal. Use the school's full figure, not just tuition.
– Grants & scholarships	Free money. Note which are renewable and what GPA keeps them.
= Net price	**What your family actually pays. The only number to compare across schools.**
Loans & work-study	Listed as "aid," but they're your money or your time. Compare separately.

WHAT THE LETTER CALLS A "$45,000 AWARD"



$15,000
Grants. The real award.

$30,000
Loans. You pay this back, with interest.

THEN MULTIPLY THE NET PRICE BY FOUR.

And ask whether the grants are guaranteed for all four years or only year one.

Appealing an offer

Write to the **financial aid office** (not admissions) with a specific ask and a reason: a change in circumstances, an error, or a competing offer from a peer school (attach it). Be brief, factual and polite. Schools adjust more often than families expect, especially before May 1.

Scholarship reality

Most scholarship money comes from colleges themselves, not outside organizations. Outside scholarships are worth applying for (local ones especially), but they're a supplement, not a plan.

Jackson's note

Net price calculators live on every college's website and take about fifteen minutes each. Run them with a parent in 11th grade. It is the least exciting, most valuable hour in this entire guide.

BONUSES & WORKSHEETS

MAKE IT YOURS

The message to send your parents, every key date on a single sheet, and five worksheets to fill in. Reading this guide is the easy part. These pages are where it turns into your plan.

How to bring your parents in	74	The deadline cheat sheet	75
1 · 4-year course plan	76	2 · Activities & impact tracker	77
3 · Summer planner	78	4 · Brag sheet	79
5 · College list builder	80	Glossary	81

print these. pens work better than good intentions.

HOW TO BRING YOUR PARENTS IN

Most students dodge the college conversation with their parents because it turns into pressure. Here's how to start it on your terms.

THE MESSAGE TO SEND (COPY IT)

> Hey — I've been reading a roadmap for college prep and I did the "am I on track" check for my grade. I want to show you what I'm on top of and the two or three things I need help with.
>
> Can we sit down for 20 minutes this weekend? I'll bring the list. There's also a one-page version for parents I'll send you first.
>
> (And there's a money question in it we should talk about before I start building a college list.)

Send the parent one-pager (→ p. 84) with it. It takes them three minutes, and it means you're not explaining everything from scratch.

HOW TO RUN THE 20 MINUTES

1. **SHOW WHAT YOU'VE GOT.**
   Your on-track checklist, filled in. Start with the boxes you checked.

2. **NAME WHAT YOU NEED.**
   Two or three things: a ride to a campus, help finding a summer program, a budget number, a counselor.

3. **ASK THE MONEY QUESTION.**
   "Roughly what can we spend per year, and will we need aid?" You don't need an exact number. You need a range before the list gets built.

4. **SET THE NEXT CHECK-IN.**
   Course selection in February. That's it. Don't make it a weekly meeting.

Jackson's note

Your parents are probably more nervous about this than you are. They just show it by asking "have you started your essay" forty times. Walk in with a list and you're the one driving.

THE DEADLINE CHEAT SHEET

Every date in this roadmap on one page. 2026–27 cycle. Confirm before you register or submit.

TESTING

PSAT/NMSQT	Oct 1–30, 2026
SAT	Aug 22 · Sep 12 · Oct 3 · Nov 7 · Dec 5 (2026) · Mar 6 · May 1 · Jun 5 (2027)
ACT	Sep 19 · Oct 17 · Dec 12 (2026) · Feb 27 · Apr 10 · Jun 12 · Jul 10 (2027)
PSAT 10 / SAT School Day	Mar 1–Apr 30, 2027
AP exams	May 3–14, 2027 · scores early July

EVERY YEAR

Feb–Mar	Course selection for next year
Jan–Mar	Selective summer program deadlines
Each semester	"Am I on track?" check + brag sheet update

JUNIOR YEAR

By end of May	Ask two teachers for recommendations
Mid-July	Personal statement draft #1
August	List finalized to 12–15

APPLYING (SENIOR YEAR)

Aug 1	Common App opens
By Oct 1	FAFSA and CSS Profile open
Oct 15	Earliest EA deadlines (UNC, UGA, Georgia Tech and others)
Nov 1 / Nov 15	Most ED and EA deadlines
Early Dec	UC and Cal State applications (confirm date)
Mid-Dec	ED/EA decisions
Jan 1–15	Regular Decision and ED II deadlines
Feb	Mid-year report sent by counselor
Mid–late Mar	Regular Decision results; aid appeals in April
May 1	**National Candidates Reply Date: deposit at one school**

THE ONLY RULE FOR ALL OF THESE

TREAT EVERY DEADLINE AS ONE WEEK EARLIER THAN PRINTED.

tear this page out. fridge. now.

4-YEAR COURSE PLAN

Fill in what you've taken and plan to take. Mark H (honors), AP, IB or DE (dual enrollment). Bring it to every course-selection meeting. **Target:** five cores every year, math through Precalculus or beyond, one language through level 4, rigor rising each year in your strengths.

SUBJECT	9TH GRADE	10TH GRADE	11TH GRADE	12TH GRADE
English				
Math				
Science				
History / Social studies				
World language				
Elective 1				
Elective 2				
# Honors / AP / IB				
GPA (unweighted)				

Check against your school

- [ ] Highest math my school offers: _____ — my path reaches it? Y / N
- [ ] APs or IB available to 10th graders: _____
- [ ] Deadline to drop AP → Honors without a "W": _____
- [ ] Does my school weight GPA? Y / N Does it rank? Y / N

Intended direction (it's fine to change)

_____

_____

Questions for my counselor

_____

_____

ACTIVITIES & IMPACT TRACKER

One row per activity. Update every semester. **Rung:** 1 Participate · 2 Contribute · 3 Lead · 4 Create. **The three numbers** are scale, output and change. In 12th grade, this page becomes your Common App activities list.

ACTIVITY & ORGANIZATION	GRADES	HRS/WK · WKS/YR	RUNG	ROLE · WHAT I SPECIFICALLY DID	THE THREE NUMBERS

Honors & awards (5 slots on the Common App)

The two-columns check

BECAUSE I CARE	BECAUSE I THINK I SHOULD

SUMMER PLANNER

Fill in each January. Deadlines for selective programs run January to March.

PLAN	DEADLINE · COST
After 9th **Explore**	
After 10th **Launch**	
After 11th **Prove**	

FOR EACH SUMMER, ONE SENTENCE WITH A NUMBER AND A VERB

Senior-year runway (summer after 11th)

- [ ] Personal statement draft #1 (by mid-July)
- [ ] Final list of 12–15 with 3+ likelies I'd attend
- [ ] Net price calculator run for every school
- [ ] Activities list drafted (10 × 150 characters)
- [ ] Brag sheet sent to both recommenders
- [ ] Every supplement and deadline in one spreadsheet

"I built…" "I ran…" "I published…" — if the sentence won't write, the plan isn't done.

BRAG SHEET

Keep this as a living document from 9th grade. Give the finished version to your counselor and teachers when you ask for letters.

Sections to include

- **Basics:** name, grade, intended major(s), the schools and deadlines you're applying to
- **Academic story:** favorite classes and why; a class where you struggled and what you did about it; an intellectual interest you pursue outside school
- **For each teacher you're asking:** what you took with them; two specific moments from their class; what you learned about how you learn
- **Activities:** from Worksheet 2, with the three numbers
- **Work and family responsibilities**
- **Summers:** one paragraph each
- **Three words a friend would use to describe you,** and a story for each
- **Context a reader should know** (only what you're comfortable sharing)
- **What you hope the letter conveys** (one sentence; a request, not a script)

SEMESTER LOG ADD A LINE EVERY SEMESTER

SEMESTER	WHAT I DID · ROLES · HOURS · AWARDS	ONE SENTENCE: WHAT I LEARNED
9th · Fall		
9th · Spring		
10th · Fall		
10th · Spring		
11th · Fall		
11th · Spring		

COLLEGE LIST BUILDER

My criteria (before any school names)

- **Programs**
- **Size · setting**
- **Distance**
- **Culture**

Family budget

- **Per year we can pay**
- **Max loans we'd accept (total)**
- **ED is an option?** Y / N
- **My GPA · test score**

SCHOOL	ADMIT %	MID-50% GPA / TEST	L / T / R	NET PRICE	PLAN · DEADLINE	SUPPLEMENTS · NOTES

Balance check: Likely ____ (3–4) · Target ____ (4–6) · Reach ____ (3–5). Every likely is a school I'd be happy to attend: Y / N. Every school's net price fits the budget or we've agreed to the stretch: Y / N.

GLOSSARY

The vocabulary nobody explains. Now somebody has.

AP / IB / DE. Advanced Placement (College Board courses with a May exam scored 1–5); International Baccalaureate (a diploma program with HL/SL courses); Dual Enrollment (college courses taken in high school for credit).

Common App. The shared application used by 1,000+ colleges; opens Aug 1. The Coalition Application and school-specific applications (UC, MIT, Georgetown) are alternatives.

Common Data Set (CDS). A standardized report each college publishes with admit rates, middle-50% scores and aid data.

Cost of attendance (COA). The full annual cost: tuition, fees, housing, food, books, travel, personal expenses.

CSS Profile. College Board's financial aid form used by about 200 mostly private colleges. Opens Oct 1.

Deferred. An early application moved into the regular pool for a second review (not a denial).

Demonstrated interest. Signals a college tracks that you're serious about it: visits, sessions, email opens, supplements. Matters at some schools, not at others.

Early Decision (ED) / ED II. Binding early plans (Nov; Jan). **Early Action (EA).** Non-binding early plan. **REA / SCEA.** Non-binding but restricts other early applications.

FAFSA. Free Application for Federal Student Aid. Required for federal aid and used by most colleges and states. Opens by Oct 1 of senior year.

FERPA waiver. Your choice to waive the right to see recommendation letters. Waive it.

Holistic review. Reading the whole application instead of applying a formula.

Letter of continued interest (LOCI). A short note to a school that waitlisted or deferred you, confirming interest and adding real updates.

Merit aid. Scholarships for achievement, regardless of need. **Need-based aid.** Awarded based on family finances.

Mid-year report. Your counselor's February submission of first-semester senior grades.

Middle 50%. The range from the 25th to 75th percentile of an admitted class's GPA or test scores. Below it → reach; inside → target; above (at a school that admits most applicants) → likely.

National Merit. A scholarship program based on the junior-year PSAT/NMSQT. Top scorers per state become Semifinalists in September of senior year.

Net price. Cost of attendance minus grants and scholarships: what a family actually pays. **Net price calculator (NPC).** A tool on every college's site that estimates it.

Rescinded. An admission offer withdrawn, typically for a serious senior-year grade drop or disciplinary issue.

Rolling admission. Applications reviewed as received; earlier is better.

School profile. The document your high school sends colleges describing its curriculum, grading, course offerings and outcomes. Your transcript is read against it.

Student Aid Index (SAI). The FAFSA's measure of what a family can contribute (replaced the EFC). Lower SAI → more need-based eligibility.

Superscore. Combining your best section scores across multiple test dates. Most colleges do this for the SAT; many for the ACT.

Supplement. A college's additional essays or short answers beyond the main application.

Test-optional / test-free. Optional: you choose whether to submit scores. Free (test-blind): scores aren't considered at all.

Waitlist. Neither admitted nor denied; may be offered a spot May–July if space opens. Accept the spot, send a LOCI, and deposit elsewhere by May 1.

Weighted / unweighted GPA. Weighted adds points for honors/AP/IB; unweighted is on a 4.0 scale. Colleges usually recalculate on their own scale.

07

PART 7

FOR PARENTS

Three pages written for you. What this process actually rewards, where your student needs you, where they need you to step back, and what to do if you get to the end of this guide and still want someone in your corner.

What we've learned from families	83	The one page for parents	84
If you still want someone in your corner	85	What comes next	86

if you're reading this, you're already doing the hard part: showing up.

WHAT WE'VE LEARNED FROM THE FAMILIES WE'VE HELPED

We've worked with hundreds of families and the counselors who serve them. The patterns are consistent enough to say out loud.

The anxious families aren't the uninformed ones. They're the ones who found out late.

Almost every parent we talk to in a senior's October wishes someone had handed them this timeline in 9th grade. Not because they would have pushed harder. Because they would have pushed on the right things. You're reading it now. **That is the single biggest advantage you can give your student, and it costs nothing.**

The transcript is the application. Everything else is read after it.

Seventy-seven percent of colleges rate grades in college-prep courses as considerably important, more than any other factor. If your family's energy is going into activities and test prep while grades slide, it's going to the wrong place. The question to ask every February: "What classes are you taking next year, and why?"

"Well-rounded" is what every applicant is.

The instinct to add one more activity is strong and usually wrong. A counselor we worked with puts it to parents this way: a family doctor, a neurologist, a neuro-oncologist. The more you specialize, the more valuable you are. Help your student go deep on one or two things, not wide on eight.

The students who do best are the ones who run their own process.

Not alone. With you beside them. But the student who emails the teacher, manages the planner and chooses the activities arrives at junior year with the skills the year demands. The one whose parent did all of it arrives without them. The hardest thing we ask parents to do is support from the side, not the front.

Money decided early prevents heartbreak late.

The worst April is the one where a student gets into the dream school and the family discovers it was never affordable. Run net price calculators in 11th grade. Set a budget. Talk about Early Decision openly before anyone applies.

THE ONE PAGE FOR PARENTS

Everything in this guide, compressed to what you need to know and when to step in.

YEAR	WHAT YOUR STUDENT IS DOING	WHAT YOU DO
9th	Building habits, choosing the course track, trying activities	Have the money conversation early. Ask about course selection in February. Let them own it.
10th	First AP, narrowing to 2–3 activities, diagnostic SAT/ACT, a real summer	Drive to three very different campuses. Help research summer programs in January. Watch for drift.
11th	Hardest year, testing in spring, leadership, asking for recommendations, drafting the list	Run net price calculators together. Set a budget. Visit over spring break. Talk openly about Early Decision.
12th	Essays in summer, early applications in October, regular in December, decisions in March	File FAFSA and CSS Profile in October. Read essays once, not ten times. Compare net prices in April. Deposit by May 1.

What matters most to colleges

Grades in challenging classes. Everything else (testing, activities, essays) is a tiebreaker at most schools and the whole decision at the most selective ones.

Three dates for your own calendar

- **February each year:** course selection. Ask what they chose and why.
- **May of 11th grade:** recommendation asks. Check that they happened.
- **October of 12th grade:** FAFSA, CSS Profile and early applications.

THE HARDEST PART FOR PARENTS

YOUR JOB IS THE BUDGET, THE DRIVES, THE REMINDERS, AND BEING THE PERSON THEY CAN BE ANXIOUS IN FRONT OF.

Their job is everything else. The students who do best have parents who hold that line.

Jackson's note

If nobody ever handed you a map for this process, there is nothing to feel behind about. This page is the map, and you being here is the part that can't be taught.

IF YOU GET TO THE END AND STILL WANT SOMEONE IN YOUR CORNER

Use this guide first. Really use it: the course plan, the on-track checks, the list builder. For a lot of families, it's enough.

But some families get to the end and realize the hard part isn't knowing what to do. It's knowing which of these hundred things matter most for *their* student, at *their* school, with *their* budget, and having someone experienced look at the plan and say "this, not that." That's what a good independent counselor does, and it's the part a guide can't.

Here's what we'd tell you about finding one, whether or not you ever talk to us:

1. **FIT MATTERS MORE THAN THE RÉSUMÉ.**
   The best counselor on paper is not always the best counselor for your kid. The right one gets more out of your student than the famous one.

2. **YOUR STUDENT SHOULD MEET THEM BEFORE YOU PAY ANYONE.**
   If a counselor won't do that, keep looking.

3. **BEWARE OF GUARANTEES.**
   Nobody can promise an admission. Anyone who does is selling something else.

4. **ASK WHO'S ACTUALLY DOING THE WORK.**
   Some firms sell a famous name and hand you a junior associate.

IF YOU'D LIKE OUR HELP

WE'VE ALREADY VETTED THE COUNSELORS. WE KNOW WHO FITS WHICH KIND OF STUDENT.

A free 30-minute matchmaking call is how it starts: we learn about your student, your goals and your budget, and recommend the counselor who fits. Your student meets them before anyone commits. **Nobody will pitch you.**

Book it at 2by2academy.co/matchmaking

Questions first? Write to team@2by2academy.co.

WHAT COMES NEXT

THE MAP IS IN YOUR HANDS. YOU DON'T HAVE TO WALK IT ALONE.

This roadmap tells you what to do and when. What it can't do is look at your transcript, your school and your family's budget and tell you which of these hundred steps matter most for *you*. That takes a person who has done this many times.

What 2by2 does

We're a matchmaker, not a counseling firm. We've vetted independent college counselors across the country (former admissions officers, people with decades of experience) and we match your family with the one who fits your student. Then we stay beside you through the whole process.

How it works

1. **A 30-minute matchmaking call.** We learn about your student, your goals and your budget.
2. **We recommend the counselor who fits,** and your student meets them before anyone commits.
3. **We stay in the room:** check-ins, support, and a team that makes it right if anything isn't working.

BOOK A MATCHMAKING CALL

2BY2ACADEMY.CO/MATCHMAKING

Bring your on-track checklists and your course plan. We'll know where to start.

© 2026 2by2 Strategy LLC. This guide is for general educational purposes and reflects policies and dates as published for the 2026–27 cycle; colleges, College Board, ACT and the U.S. Department of Education may change them. Always confirm current requirements with the official source. Questions: team@2by2academy.co

2by2 ACADEMY

Two by Two Strategy

Two by your side.